

Open Translator's Notes is based on: Open Translator's Notes, [SIL International](#), 2024, which is licensed under a [CC BY-SA 4.0 license](#).

This PDF version is provided under the same license.

1 John

1 John 1:1

Section 1:1–4: John explains his authority and his reasons for writing this letter

Read 1:1–4 carefully in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Section Theme: These verses form an introduction to the whole letter. In them John states the authority which he has for giving instructions to his readers. He also explains what his purpose is in writing the letter. His authority is the fact that he had personally been with Jesus Christ, the eternal Word of God. His purpose in writing the letter is that the people he is writing to may truly share the fellowship he has with God.

1:1–3 (Sentence Breaks)

These verses are all one long and complicated sentence in the Greek and in some English versions such as RSV. The subject and main verb of this sentence come in verse 3, “We proclaim,” but its topic is at the end of verse 1, “the Word of life.” So in translation these verses may need to be split into shorter sentences and the parts may need to be reordered to make the meaning clear. See 1:1–3 in the Display.

1:1

That which was from the beginning, which we have heard, which we have seen with our own eyes, which we have gazed upon and touched with our own hands—this is the Word of life.

- ¶ I am writing to you^(plur) about him who is God’s message to people and gives people real life. Long ago he already existed even before the beginning of the world. But now we^(excl) ourselves have heard him talking, and we have seen him, and we have watched him doing things, and our hands have touched him.

(GNT:) We write to you: (Discourse Feature) The fact that this is a letter is obvious from the way John writes. In the Greek, however, there is no formal beginning to the letter, naming the writer and the people he is writing to, as there is in Paul’s letters. In your translation it may be necessary to add some simple introduction such as “We write to you,” so that readers are not confused about whether they are reading a letter or a history or some other sort of literature.

(GNT:) We: (Pronoun System) This letter was written by only one person, John, but throughout chapter 1 he uses the plural, We, because he is associating himself in what he is saying with the other apostles who also

lived with Jesus. If this meaning will not be conveyed by We in your translation, it would be better to say “I write...,” and then “the other apostles and I have heard...,” etc. As an alternative the book introduction could contain an explanation of who John means by We.

That which was: (Pronoun Reference) This refers to the “Word of life” (see the note below). Since the “Word of life” is really Jesus, it may be better to refer to it as “he/him” in your translation.

from the beginning: (Meaning) This refers to the beginning of the world. John is saying that the Word existed even before the creation of the world. He does not mean that the Word came into existence when the world was created.

with our own eyes: (Focus) All the four statements, “we heard...,” “we saw...,” “we looked at...,” “we touched...,” are emphasizing the fact that although the Word had existed from before creation, John and the other apostles had actually been with Jesus, who was the Word, when he was in this world. None of the four statements is more prominent than the others, so if phrases such as with our eyes are unnatural in translation they can be left implicit. But make sure that the emphasis on John’s personal experience is being clearly communicated.

gazed upon: (Meaning) What is meant here is deliberate, continual, detailed observing, rather than the simple “seeing” of the previous clause.

our own hands: (Focus) See note on “with our eyes” above.

Word of life: (Meaning) This means the word which is life, the word which is the source of life, as in John 14:6. It refers to Jesus, but it would be wrong to make his name explicit as John is not here emphasizing Jesus as a person. He is emphasizing the fact that Jesus is the one who causes us to be truly alive by showing us what God is really like.

Word: (Special Biblical Term) This is a Biblical technical term as in John 1:1. It refers to God’s words or message to people in which he shows them what he is really like. In translation it may be necessary to make it clear that this is the “Word of God.”

(JB:) who is life: (Pronoun Reference) If you need to make “God” explicit in the phrase “the Word of life” (or, “the Word, who is life”), make sure that this phrase who is life refers to the Word and not to God. See Display.

1 John 1:2

Section 1:1–4: John explains his authority and his reasons for writing this letter

Read 1:1–4 carefully in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Section Theme: These verses form an introduction to the whole letter. In them John states the authority which he has for giving instructions to his readers. He also explains what his purpose is in writing the letter. His authority is the fact that he had personally been with Jesus Christ, the eternal Word of God. His purpose in writing the letter is that the people he is writing to may truly share the fellowship he has with God.

1:2b we have seen it

- We^(excl) saw him.

1:2 (Parenthesis)

This verse is a comment about the Word of life, which John has just mentioned. In the next verse (1:3) he continues what he has been saying about the subject of his letter.

1:2a And this is the life that was revealed;

- God showed to people this person who gives real life.
- God caused him to become a human being so that people could see him.

And this is the life: (Meaning) This also refers to Jesus. See the note on 1:1 “Word of life” above.

was revealed: (Alternative Interpretations) Two interpretations of the form of the Greek verb are possible here:

1. It probably means “he was revealed (by God),” “God caused him to become a human being, who people could see.” (BSB, JB, NEB, KJV, RSV, LB)
2. Some think it means “he appeared,” “he became visible.” (NIV, GNT, JBP)

1:2c and testified to it,

- So we are telling you^(plur) the truth about him.

testified: (Meaning) This means to tell or confirm the truth about something which one has personally experienced or seen.

1:2d and we proclaim to you the eternal life

- We are telling you that this person who gives life exists forever,

proclaim: (Meaning) This means to testify to something openly or publicly.

the eternal life: (Special Biblical Term) This is a biblical term which describes the type of life which God has and which he gives to us. It refers to both the length of that life and to its quality. It means life which is never-ending and which is heavenly rather than earthly. In this verse it refers to Jesus, just as “the life” does at the beginning of the verse. It is emphasizing that the life which Jesus brings us has always existed in heaven.

1:2e that was with the Father

- and that from long ago he was together with God the Father,

with the Father: (Meaning) This is very similar to John 1:1 “the Word was with God.” It means that God and the Word (the Life) never existed separately, they were always together.

Father: (Expression) If it is necessary to specify whose father this is, say “our Father” here.

1:2f and was revealed to us.

- but now God has shown him to us.^(excl)

was revealed to us: (Alternative Interpretations) See the note on 1:2a “revealed.” The same two interpretations are found here.

1 John 1:3

Section 1:1–4: John explains his authority and his reasons for writing this letter

Read 1:1–4 carefully in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Section Theme: These verses form an introduction to the whole letter. In them John states the authority which he has for giving instructions to his readers. He also explains what his purpose is in writing the letter. His authority is the fact that he had personally been with Jesus Christ, the eternal Word of God. His purpose in writing the letter is that the people he is writing to may truly share the fellowship he has with God.

1:3a We proclaim to you what we have seen and heard,

- So this person who we^(excl) have seen and heard, he is the same one we are telling you^(plur) about,

We proclaim....: (Theme) This verse is the main point of the paragraph 1–4. John repeats what he is telling his readers in order to emphasize his purpose in

telling it to them, namely that he and they may be united in fellowship. In order to make this emphasis clear in translation it may be necessary to say

The reason why we are telling you (plur) about this person who we have seen and heard is that we want you to be united with us in trusting him.

what we have seen: (Pronoun Reference) John is still referring to Jesus as the “Word of life” (see the note on 1:1). That is why the form what is used here in English, rather than “who.” In your translation you should make it clear that this whole passage is about Jesus.

1:3b

so that you also may have fellowship with us.

- so that you also may believe in him and so you may join in fellowship with us.
- in order that you too may join us in trusting him.

so that: (Logical Relationship) John is saying that he is telling his readers about Jesus so that they may believe the same things about Jesus as he does and thus they may have fellowship with him and the apostles. These steps in the argument may need to be made clear in translation. See the Display.

also: (Emphasis) The word translated also occurs twice in the Greek, “we proclaim to you also” and “so that you also may have fellowship with us.” John is emphasizing that both the gospel and fellowship are not only for the apostles but for his readers also.

may have fellowship with us: (Meaning) John means that his readers should continue to have fellowship with him. He is not implying that they need to become Christians so that they will have fellowship. Throughout this letter he repeatedly states that he is confident that they already believe in Jesus.

fellowship: (Special Biblical Term) See fellowship in Key Biblical Terms. This term means being united, sharing in something on the basis of mutual agreement, especially in God’s blessings. That is why John uses it here to refer both to our fellowship with one another and to our fellowship with God.

1:3c

And this fellowship of ours is with the Father and with His Son, Jesus Christ.

- For we ourselves are joining in fellowship with God our Father, and Jesus Christ, his Son.

this fellowship of ours: (Alternative Interpretations) There are two interpretations of ours here:

1. It is probably exclusive, meaning “(fellowship) of us apostles.”
2. Some think it is inclusive, meaning “(fellowship) of you together with us apostles.”

1 John 1:4

Section 1:1–4: John explains his authority and his reasons for writing this letter

Read 1:1–4 carefully in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Section Theme: These verses form an introduction to the whole letter. In them John states the authority which he has for giving instructions to his readers. He also explains what his purpose is in writing the letter. His authority is the fact that he had personally been with Jesus Christ, the eternal Word of God. His purpose in writing the letter is that the people he is writing to may truly share the fellowship he has with God.

1:4a

We write these things

- So I am writing about these things to you

these things: (Alternative Interpretations) There are two opinions about what the words these things refer to here:

1. It probably refers to what John has said in verses 1–3.
2. Some think it refers to the rest of the letter.

1:4b

so that our joy may be complete.

- so that you may join in fellowship with us,^(excl) and so our^(incl) joy may be very much.

so that our joy may be complete: (Logical Relationship) John’s purpose in writing is not primarily to make himself joyful. He is writing so that his readers will learn about true fellowship and have fellowship with him. If they do, that is what will cause him to be joyful. If this is not clear in translation some of this information should be made explicit. See the Display.

our joy: (Text) The KJV “your joy” is from an inferior Greek text. The other versions have “our joy.”

our: (Alternative Interpretations) There are two interpretations of this word here:

1. It is probably inclusive, meaning “(joy) of you and us apostles.”
2. Some think it is exclusive, meaning “(joy) of us apostles.”

complete: (Meaning) This means “as great as it can be,” “without any sadness or anything to spoil it.”

1 John 1:5

Section 1:5–2:27: Live pure lives and remain united with God

Read 1:5–2:27 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John is appealing to his readers to live morally pure lives and to remain united with God. He gives the following reasons for this:

1:5–2:2	God has made it possible for us to be morally pure just as he is.
2:3–11	We ought to love our fellow Christians as Christ did.
2:12–27	The readers ought not to love the non-Christian world but they should live according to the truth that God has shown to them.

Paragraph 1:5–10

Read 1:5–10 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: In the previous verses John expresses the desire that his readers should share the fellowship which he has with God. In 1:5–10 he makes the point that God is morally pure and holy, and therefore those who sin cannot have fellowship with God unless they confess their sins and God forgives them. His purpose is to persuade his readers to confess their sins.

1:5a

And this is the message we have heard from Him and announce to you:

- ¶ But the message which Jesus Christ told us,^(excl) and which we are proclaiming to you,^(plur) is this,

And: (Discourse Feature) Because the previous verses contrast with what John is saying in 1:5–10, a connecting word such as “But” may be needed here instead of And. GNT uses “Now,” which in English indicates a mild contrast.

this: (Pronoun Reference) The word this refer to the statement “God is light...”

we: (Pronoun Reference) John is referring to himself and the other apostles.

from Him: (Pronoun Reference) In order to make clear who this refers to, it will probably be necessary to use a fuller form, for example, “from Jesus Christ,” or “from God’s Son” as in GNT.

1:5b

God is light,

- God is good and pure like light.

1:5c

and in Him there is no darkness at all.

- There is nothing at all evil or unpleasant like darkness about him.
- He is in no way evil.

1:5b–c

God is light: (Meaning) This is a description of God’s nature or character. Be sure in translation it does not sound as if John is identifying God with some particular light. The following clause confirms this statement by denying its opposite: “in him there is no darkness at all.”

light...darkness: (Metaphor) In the Bible “light” symbolizes goodness and purity and the truth that comes from God’s revelation of himself. “Darkness” symbolizes ignorance and all that is evil. If these symbols are not clear in your language, it may be necessary to state the meaning explicitly in your translation. See the Display.

1 John 1:6

Section 1:5–2:27: Live pure lives and remain united with God

Read 1:5–2:27 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John is appealing to his readers to live morally pure lives and to remain united with God. He gives the following reasons for this:

1:5–2:2	God has made it possible for us to be morally pure just as he is.
2:3–11	We ought to love our fellow Christians as Christ did.
2:12–27	The readers ought not to love the non-Christian world but they should live according to the truth that God has shown to them.

Paragraph 1:5–10

Read 1:5–10 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: In the previous verses John expresses the desire that his readers should share the fellowship which he has with God. In 1:5–10 he makes the point that God is morally pure and holy, and therefore those who sin cannot have fellowship with God unless they confess their sins and God forgives them. His purpose is to persuade his readers to confess their sins.

1:6a**If we say we have fellowship with Him**

- So if we^(incl) were to say that we are joining in fellowship with God

(GNT:) then: (Logical Relationship) 1:6 gives the conclusion which John draws from what he has said in the previous verse about God being light. This connection may be clearer if some linking word such as “so” or “then” is used. See GNT, LB, JBP.

If we say: (Expression) These words also occur at the beginning of 1:8 and 1:10. In each case they introduce some false teaching which John wants to expose. He is not implying that he or his readers did actually say such things. He is quoting what the false teachers say and what his readers would say if they followed them. It may be more natural in your language to say, “If/When somebody says...”

with Him: (Pronoun Reference) It may be clearer or more natural to say “with God” here as in JB.

1:6b**yet walk in the darkness,**

- while we are still living in the darkness of evil,
- when we are continually doing wrong/evil things,

walk in the darkness: (Metaphor) The picture of a person walking in darkness refers to someone not knowing the truth and constantly doing what is wrong.

1:6c**we lie and do not practice the truth.**

- what we are saying is untrue, and our behavior shows that we have rejected the true things which God has revealed.

do not practice the truth: (Meaning) John is saying that not only would such a statement (1:6a) be a lie, but also the person who said it would not be living in accordance with the truth that God has revealed about himself.

1 John 1:7**Section 1:5–2:27: Live pure lives and remain united with God**

Read 1:5–2:27 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John is appealing to his readers to live morally pure lives and to remain united with God. He gives the following reasons for this:

1:5–2:2	God has made it possible for us to be morally pure just as he is.
---------	---

2:3–11	We ought to love our fellow Christians as Christ did.
2:12–27	The readers ought not to love the non-Christian world but they should live according to the truth that God has shown to them.

Paragraph 1:5–10

Read 1:5–10 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: In the previous verses John expresses the desire that his readers should share the fellowship which he has with God. In 1:5–10 he makes the point that God is morally pure and holy, and therefore those who sin cannot have fellowship with God unless they confess their sins and God forgives them. His purpose is to persuade his readers to confess their sins.

1:7a**But if we walk in the light**

- But if instead we^(incl) live in the light of God’s purity,
- But when we do right things as God’s light shows us,

if we...: (Expression) Here John is giving a positive contrast to the last verse, showing what Christians should be doing. Therefore it may be appropriate to use “we” here even if you have used “somebody” in 1:6.

walk in the light: (Metaphor) This means behaving consistently with what God has revealed about his nature and his will. This is clearly contrasted with “walk in the darkness” in the previous verse.

1:7b**as He is in the light,**

- just as God always acts rightly, in accordance with his light/purity,

He is in the light: (Meaning) Notice the difference from 1:5. Here John says that God is in the light. This is focusing on his actions, which are always good and pure and in accordance with his nature.

1:7c**we have fellowship with one another,**

- then we are truly joining in fellowship with each other,

fellowship with one another: (Focus) The obvious consequence of us walking in the light would be that we would have fellowship with God. But here John is focusing on the fact that doing God’s will causes us to be united with all God’s people. He is warning his readers against the false teachers, who led their

followers to break away from fellowship with other Christians.

**1:7d
and the blood of Jesus His Son cleanses us**

- and the death of God's Son, Jesus, is making us clean/pure in God's sight.

blood of Jesus His Son: (Meaning) This term is often used in the N.T. to refer to Jesus' violent death, which removes our sin in the same way that the blood of the sacrificed animals did in the O.T.

cleanses: (Metaphor) This is a metaphor for removing from us all that would make us unacceptable to God, that is, all evil. Note that here John is referring to the process that continues throughout our Christian lives.

**1:7e
from all sin.**

- It is removing all our wrong deeds from us.

1 John 1:8

Section 1:5–2:27: Live pure lives and remain united with God

Read 1:5–2:27 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John is appealing to his readers to live morally pure lives and to remain united with God. He gives the following reasons for this:

1:5–2:2	God has made it possible for us to be morally pure just as he is.
2:3–11	We ought to love our fellow Christians as Christ did.
2:12–27	The readers ought not to love the non-Christian world but they should live according to the truth that God has shown to them.

Paragraph 1:5–10

Read 1:5–10 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: In the previous verses John expresses the desire that his readers should share the fellowship which he has with God. In 1:5–10 he makes the point that God is morally pure and holy, and therefore those who sin cannot have fellowship with God unless they confess their sins and God forgives them. His purpose is to persuade his readers to confess their sins.

**1:8a
If we say we have no sin,**

- If we^(incl) were to say that we never sin,

- If we claimed that we are people who never do wrong,

If we say: (Expression) See the note on 1:6.

have no sin: (Meaning) Here John is referring to those who claim that whatever Christians do is right and therefore Christians cannot be said to commit sin.

**1:8b
we deceive ourselves,**

- then what we are saying is deceiving us,

we deceive ourselves: (Meaning) It is not true that Christians never sin. So if we say things like this we are confusing or deceiving ourselves and others.

**1:8c
and the truth is not in us.**

- and we do not know the true things which God has revealed at all.

the truth is not in us: (Collocation) In some languages it is not natural to say that an abstract idea like "truth" is "in" someone. John means that if we say that we have no sin, then it is clear that we do not know the truth which God has revealed. God has shown in the Old Testament and the Gospels what sin is. So if we say something different about sin it cannot be true.

1 John 1:9

Section 1:5–2:27: Live pure lives and remain united with God

Read 1:5–2:27 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John is appealing to his readers to live morally pure lives and to remain united with God. He gives the following reasons for this:

1:5–2:2	God has made it possible for us to be morally pure just as he is.
2:3–11	We ought to love our fellow Christians as Christ did.
2:12–27	The readers ought not to love the non-Christian world but they should live according to the truth that God has shown to them.

Paragraph 1:5–10

Read 1:5–10 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: In the previous verses John expresses the desire that his readers should share the fellowship which he has with God. In 1:5–10 he makes the point that God is morally pure and holy, and there-

fore those who sin cannot have fellowship with God unless they confess their sins and God forgives them. His purpose is to persuade his readers to confess their sins.

1:9a

If we confess our sins,

- But if instead we^(incl) say openly to God that we have done wrong,

If we: (Expression) Here John is giving a positive contrast to the previous verse, just as 1:7 contrasted with 1:6. See the note on 1:7.

confess: (Meaning) This means to admit freely to God things which previously we have tried to hide or deny.

1:9b

He is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness.

- then he will forgive us for all those wrong deeds and he will remove all our wrong deeds from us and make us clean/pure in his sight because he has said he will forgive us and he always does what he says he will do and because he only does right.

He is faithful and just: (Logical Relationship) A literal translation of this verse might suggest that God is faithful and just only if we confess our sins. A good translation needs to make it clear that God has promised to forgive and cleanse us if we confess our sins, and we can be sure he will do this, since he always does what is right and he is always faithful to his promises.

forgive us...cleanse us: (Meaning) This is referring to the fact that every time we confess a sin to God he forgives the sin and makes us once more acceptable to him.

unrighteousness: (Meaning) This word is similar to “sin” but it emphasizes everything about our character and behavior that is contrary to what God wants.

1 John 1:10

Section 1:5–2:27: Live pure lives and remain united with God

Read 1:5–2:27 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John is appealing to his readers to live morally pure lives and to remain united with God. He gives the following reasons for this:

1:5–2:2	God has made it possible for us to be morally pure just as he is.
---------	---

2:3–11	We ought to love our fellow Christians as Christ did.
2:12–27	The readers ought not to love the non-Christian world but they should live according to the truth that God has shown to them.

Paragraph 1:5–10

Read 1:5–10 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: In the previous verses John expresses the desire that his readers should share the fellowship which he has with God. In 1:5–10 he makes the point that God is morally pure and holy, and therefore those who sin cannot have fellowship with God unless they confess their sins and God forgives them. His purpose is to persuade his readers to confess their sins.

1:10a

If we say we have not sinned,

- If we^(incl) were to say that we have never sinned,
- If we claim that we have never done any wrong deed,

If we say: (Expression) See the note on 1:6.

have not sinned: (Meaning) This is different from the beginning of 1:8. Here John is dealing with those who claim that although other Christians sometimes sin, they themselves have not done anything that needs to be confessed.

1:10b

we make Him out to be a liar,

- then by those words we are saying that God is a liar, since he has said that all people have sinned,

make Him out to be a liar: (Logical Relationship) Perhaps it is not clear why John says that claiming not to have sinned is making God out to be a liar. The reason is that God has said that all people have sinned. Therefore anyone who says that we have not sinned is thereby saying that God has lied. You may need to state this reasoning explicitly in your translation. See the Display.

1:10c

and His word is not in us.

- and if we do that, we have not accepted his word at all.
- and that shows that we do not let what he says affect us.

His word is not in us: (Meaning) If we call God a liar, it shows that we have not accepted what he has said or allowed it to affect our lives.

1 John 2:1

Section 1:5–2:27: Live pure lives and remain united with God

Read 1:5–2:27 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John is appealing to his readers to live morally pure lives and to remain united with God. He gives the following reasons for this:

1:5–2:2	God has made it possible for us to be morally pure just as he is.
2:3–11	We ought to love our fellow Christians as Christ did.
2:12–27	The readers ought not to love the non-Christian world but they should live according to the truth that God has shown to them.

Paragraph 2:1–2

Read 2:1–2 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: John has just written about Christians sinning, and one of his purposes in writing is that Christians should not sin but be pure like God. In these verses he appeals to his readers not to sin, and he reminds them that even if a Christian sins, Christ, through his death for us, provides a way for God to forgive us.

2:1a

My little children, I am writing these things to you so that you will not sin.

- ¶I You^(plur) who are like my children, the reason I am writing these instructions to you is so that you will not do wrong deeds.

My little children: (Cross-cultural Difference) John is writing as an old man and a respected leader to Christians in churches for which he is responsible. He is expressing an affectionate, fatherly attitude to them. Consider if in your language such a person would use the term “children” in such a situation. If he would not, then it would be right to translate it with some other more appropriate term.

I am writing: (Pronoun System) Notice that John now changes from writing in the plural “we” to the singular “I.”

these things: (Pronoun Reference) The words these things refer to what he has just said, especially in 1:5–7, about the way Christians should behave.

you will not sin: (Meaning) This follows closely what John has said in 1:9–10, that when Christians do wrong

they must confess it. Here he goes on to say that a Christian should strive at all costs to avoid sinning.

2:1b

But if anyone does sin,

- But if anyone of us^(incl) does do any wrong deeds,

2:1c

we have an advocate before the Father—

- God will forgive him because there is a person who stands before God our Father and asks God to forgive us.

we have...: (Logical Relationship) Although Christians should strive not to sin, it may happen that they do sin. John says that if they do sin, they can still be forgiven because of what Christ does for them. If this reasoning is not clear in your translation, you may need to make explicit here that this includes the idea of God forgiving sin. See the Display.

we have an advocate before the Father: (Focus) The focus here is not on what Jesus does, but rather it is on the fact that God will forgive us. He forgives us because our friend Jesus is always with him speaking for us. This focus may need to be made clear in your translation. See the Display.

an advocate before the Father: (Meaning) See advocate in Key Biblical Terms. The Greek word which this phrase translates refers to anyone, not necessarily a lawyer, who defends a person who is accused of something in court. In the case which John is referring to here, God is the judge and Satan is accusing us of breaking God’s laws.

2:1d

Jesus Christ, the Righteous One.

- That person is Jesus Christ, who is completely good in God’s sight.

the Righteous One: (Alternative Interpretations) See just in Key Biblical Terms. The Greek word translated the Righteous One has more than one sense.

1. In this sentence it probably means that everything Jesus does is good and right in God’s sight. (This is the sense in which John usually uses this word.)
2. JB, NEB and JBP translate it as “just,” meaning that Jesus treats everyone fairly in his dealings and judgments.

1 John 2:2

Section 1:5–2:27: Live pure lives and remain united with God

Read 1:5–2:27 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John is appealing to his readers to live morally pure lives and to remain united with God. He gives the following reasons for this:

1:5-2:2	God has made it possible for us to be morally pure just as he is.
2:3-11	We ought to love our fellow Christians as Christ did.
2:12-27	The readers ought not to love the non-Christian world but they should live according to the truth that God has shown to them.

Paragraph 2:1-2

Read 2:1-2 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: John has just written about Christians sinning, and one of his purposes in writing is that Christians should not sin but be pure like God. In these verses he appeals to his readers not to sin, and he reminds them that even if a Christian sins, Christ, through his death for us, provides a way for God to forgive us.

2:2a

He Himself is the atoning sacrifice for our sins,

- It was Jesus who God punished for our wrong deeds instead of us by causing him to die on the cross.

the atoning sacrifice: (Meaning) See reconcile in Key Biblical Terms. This shows the basis on which Jesus is able to ask God to forgive us. It is because he himself bore all the punishment which God had ordered us to bear for our sins. He did this by his death, and in this way he took the place of the sacrificial animal which God had said in the Old Testament must be the payment for sin.

2:2b

and not only for ours but also for the sins of the whole world.

- And because of him God forgives not only our sins, but also the sins of all people everywhere.

the whole world: (Figure of Speech) See world in Key Biblical Terms. Here this phrase means all the people in the world.

1 John 2:3

Section 1:5-2:27: Live pure lives and remain united with God

Read 1:5-2:27 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John is appealing to his readers to live morally pure lives and to remain united with God. He gives the following reasons for this:

1:5-2:2	God has made it possible for us to be morally pure just as he is.
2:3-11	We ought to love our fellow Christians as Christ did.
2:12-27	The readers ought not to love the non-Christian world but they should live according to the truth that God has shown to them.

Paragraph 2:3-6

Read 2:3-6 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: Here John begins to give the reason why we should not sin. He says that we should obey God's commands as Jesus did. If we do that our behavior shows that we know God.

2:3a

By this we can be sure that we have come to know Him:

- ¶ But the thing which makes us^(incl) certain that we have become people who know God

to know Him: (Multiple Senses) The word know is here used in the sense of knowing someone personally as you would know your family and friends. This is different from knowing who someone is, or knowing about them.

Him: (Alternative Interpretations) There are two opinions about who the word Him refers to here:

1. GNT, JB, JBP make it clear that this refers to God.
2. Some commentators think it refers to Jesus.

2:3b

if we keep His commandments.

- is this: the fact that we are doing what he told us we should do.

if we keep His commandments: (Emotive Impact) This clause is emphasized in the Greek because John is telling his readers that this is what they should do. This emphasis can be shown in your translation by making if we keep His commandments the main clause of the sentence. For example:

“We should obey his commands because that is what will show us that we really know him.”

keep: (Tense) The tense of the verb here implies continual obedience.

1 John 2:4

Section 1:5–2:27: Live pure lives and remain united with God

Read 1:5–2:27 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John is appealing to his readers to live morally pure lives and to remain united with God. He gives the following reasons for this:

1:5–2:2	God has made it possible for us to be morally pure just as he is.
2:3–11	We ought to love our fellow Christians as Christ did.
2:12–27	The readers ought not to love the non-Christian world but they should live according to the truth that God has shown to them.

Paragraph 2:3–6

Read 2:3–6 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: Here John begins to give the reason why we should not sin. He says that we should obey God's commands as Jesus did. If we do that our behavior shows that we know God.

2:4a

If anyone says, "I know Him,"

- So if anyone says that he is a person who knows God,

If anyone: (Meaning) This phrase just means "anyone who," or "if anyone." It also applies to anyone among John's readers, so it could be translated "if you."

2:4b

but does not keep His commandments,

- but he is not doing what God has said people should do,

2:4c

he is a liar, and the truth is not in him.

- he is lying and he does not know the true things which God has revealed.

he is a liar: (Meaning) This means "he is lying when he says that." It does not mean "he is a habitual liar."

the truth is not in him: (Collocation) Here John means that such a person has clearly not accepted the truth which God has revealed. See the note on 1:8c.

1 John 2:5

Section 1:5–2:27: Live pure lives and remain united with God

Read 1:5–2:27 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John is appealing to his readers to live morally pure lives and to remain united with God. He gives the following reasons for this:

1:5–2:2	God has made it possible for us to be morally pure just as he is.
2:3–11	We ought to love our fellow Christians as Christ did.
2:12–27	The readers ought not to love the non-Christian world but they should live according to the truth that God has shown to them.

Paragraph 2:3–6

Read 2:3–6 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: Here John begins to give the reason why we should not sin. He says that we should obey God's commands as Jesus did. If we do that our behavior shows that we know God.

2:5a

But if anyone keeps His word,

- But anyone who does what God has said,

His word: (Lexical Problem) This refers to the same thing as "His commandments" in 2:3–4.

2:5b

the love of God has been truly perfected in him.

- his love for God is perfect.
- he truly loves God.

the love of God: (Alternative Interpretations) The phrase the love of God could be understood in two different ways:

1. It probably means "that person loves God" (BSB, RSV, GNT, LB, JBP). (John says the same thing in 5:3 in almost the same words.)
2. However, some think it means "God loves that person" (NIV, JB, NEB).

been truly perfected: (Figure of Speech) John means that such a person loves God completely; his love has the full outcome that it should have.

2:5c

By this we know that we are in Him:

- So the thing which shows us^(incl) that we are united with God is this:

By this: (Logical Connection) The word this is pointing forward to the next verse. John is saying that the thing which shows whether we are “in God” is our behavior or manner of life (2:6 BSB “walk”). In 2:6 he explains why our behavior will show this. It may be necessary in translation to make some of these connections explicit.

in Him: (Collocation) This is John’s way of talking about our personal relationship and union with God. (See John 15:4–7, 17:21, 23). In some languages it sounds like nonsense if one talks about someone being “in” someone else. In such cases the translator needs to find how a very close relationship or association of two things would be referred to. See GNT “in union with God.”

1 John 2:6

Section 1:5–2:27: Live pure lives and remain united with God

Read 1:5–2:27 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John is appealing to his readers to live morally pure lives and to remain united with God. He gives the following reasons for this:

1:5–2:2	God has made it possible for us to be morally pure just as he is.
2:3–11	We ought to love our fellow Christians as Christ did.
2:12–27	The readers ought not to love the non-Christian world but they should live according to the truth that God has shown to them.

Paragraph 2:3–6

Read 2:3–6 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: Here John begins to give the reason why we should not sin. He says that we should obey God’s commands as Jesus did. If we do that our behavior shows that we know God.

2:6a

Whoever claims to abide in Him

- that if anyone says that he is united with God,

abide in Him: (Collocation) This has the same meaning as are “in Him” in 2:5. See the note on 2:5c.

2:6b

must walk as Jesus walked.

- he ought to behave just as Jesus behaved.
- he should act just as Jesus acted.

must walk: (Connotation) John is giving an implied command to his readers. He is saying that since they claim to live in God they ought to behave as Jesus did. In translation it is important that this should be understood as a command and not just as a statement.

walk: (Metaphor) Here, walk is used as a metaphor for the way we live and behave. The point of similarity is that both walking and behavior are actions that continue for some time and are done on purpose. If there is no common metaphor for this in your language, it is best to translate the meaning “should live” directly, as GNT, JB and NEB have done.

1 John 2:7

Section 1:5–2:27: Live pure lives and remain united with God

Read 1:5–2:27 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John is appealing to his readers to live morally pure lives and to remain united with God. He gives the following reasons for this:

1:5–2:2	God has made it possible for us to be morally pure just as he is.
2:3–11	We ought to love our fellow Christians as Christ did.
2:12–27	The readers ought not to love the non-Christian world but they should live according to the truth that God has shown to them.

Paragraph 2:7–11

Read 2:7–11 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: These verses show which of God’s commands John particularly wanted his readers to obey, namely the command to love our fellow Christians. If we obey that command we are living according to the truth and purity of God’s nature, which John calls “the light”.

2:7a

Beloved, I am not writing to you a new commandment,

- ¶ My dear people, the matter which I am writing to you^(plur) about is a thing which God says you should do, and it is not something which you have never heard before this.

Beloved: (Text) KJV, LB and JBP have “brothers,” which comes from an inferior Greek text.

Beloved: (Meaning) John shows his loving attitude by addressing his readers as “dear ones” or “you whom

I love.” The Greek word he uses is closely related to that for “love,” which is his theme in this paragraph. It does not mean “friends” in the sense of companions or partners.

not writing to you a new commandment: (Focus) John’s theme here is that Christians should love one another. This follows from the importance of behaving as Christ behaved (2:6). In 2:7–8 he is showing that God has commanded us to love one another. He says this command is not new to his readers because Jesus gave it many years before (John 13:34). Yet Jesus called it a “new command.” John goes on to say that it is “new” in the sense that Jesus’ life and death showed for the first time what true love is, and it is also “new” in how it affects Christians’ lives.

2:7b

but an old one, which you have had from the beginning.

- No, it is that same command which you have known from the time when you began to follow Christ.

an old one: (Meaning) John means that the command to love was one of the main points of the Christian instruction his readers had received in the past.

from the beginning: (Meaning) This refers to the time when they first became Christians. This is different from the meaning of the same phrase in 1:1.

2:7c

This commandment is the message you have heard.

- So this command was given to you in the past, for it is God’s message which you heard then.

1 John 2:8

Section 1:5–2:27: Live pure lives and remain united with God

Read 1:5–2:27 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John is appealing to his readers to live morally pure lives and to remain united with God. He gives the following reasons for this:

1:5–2:2	God has made it possible for us to be morally pure just as he is.
2:3–11	We ought to love our fellow Christians as Christ did.
2:12–27	The readers ought not to love the non-Christian world but they should live according to the truth that God has shown to them.

Paragraph 2:7–11

Read 2:7–11 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: These verses show which of God’s commands John particularly wanted his readers to obey, namely the command to love our fellow Christians. If we obey that command we are living according to the truth and purity of God’s nature, which John calls “the light”.

2:8a

Then again, I am also writing to you a new commandment,

- However this command which I am writing to you about is also new.
- But there is also something new about it.

a new commandment: (Meaning) This refers again to the command to love one another. See the note on 2:7a. John is not referring to a second command.

2:8b

which is true in Him and also in you.

- The way Christ lived has shown us^(incl) that this command is truly new, and your lives also show that it is truly new,

which is true in Him and also in you: (Alternative Interpretations) There are different opinions about what the Greek words refer to in this part of the verse:

1. John is probably saying, “the newness of this new command is truly seen in him and you.” This is the opinion of most commentators, since it is the most natural meaning of the Greek.
2. Most English versions give the meaning as, “the truth of this new command is seen in him and you.” However, this is not what the Greek appears to mean.

2:8c

For the darkness is fading

- because in his life and in your lives the darkness of evil and ignorance becomes less

2:8d

and the true light is already shining.

- and people see God’s truth like a light in Christ’s life and your lives.

2:8c–d

For: (Logical Connection) 2:8c–d shows in what way the command is new in Christ and in John’s readers. Christ was God’s light coming into the world driving away the darkness by his love, and for the Christians their whole lives and behavior were being changed as they loved one another.

darkness...light: (Metaphor) See the note on 1:5b–c.

1 John 2:9

Section 1:5–2:27: Live pure lives and remain united with God

Read 1:5–2:27 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John is appealing to his readers to live morally pure lives and to remain united with God. He gives the following reasons for this:

1:5–2:2	God has made it possible for us to be morally pure just as he is.
2:3–11	We ought to love our fellow Christians as Christ did.
2:12–27	The readers ought not to love the non-Christian world but they should live according to the truth that God has shown to them.

Paragraph 2:7–11

Read 2:7–11 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: These verses show which of God's commands John particularly wanted his readers to obey, namely the command to love our fellow Christians. If we obey that command we are living according to the truth and purity of God's nature, which John calls "the light".

2:9a

If anyone claims to be in the light

- So anyone who says he always behaves rightly in accordance with God's light/purity

in the light: (Meaning) This is the same phrase as in 1:7. It refers to living and behaving in a good and pure way as God does.

2:9b

but hates his brother,

- while he is treating a fellow Christian unkindly,
- while he is doing evil to another believer,

hates: (Multiple Senses) This is the opposite of "loves" in 2:10. It refers to the way one person behaves towards another person, not just to the feelings he has about that person.

brother: (Multiple Senses) This has the sense here of "fellow Christian."

2:9c

he is still in the darkness.

- that person is in fact living in the darkness of evil and ignorance even now.

still: (Emphasis) John is emphasizing that such a person is not sinning only in hating his brother. If a person hates his brother, it shows that he has always been in the darkness and has not yet come out of it.

1 John 2:10

Section 1:5–2:27: Live pure lives and remain united with God

Read 1:5–2:27 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John is appealing to his readers to live morally pure lives and to remain united with God. He gives the following reasons for this:

1:5–2:2	God has made it possible for us to be morally pure just as he is.
2:3–11	We ought to love our fellow Christians as Christ did.
2:12–27	The readers ought not to love the non-Christian world but they should live according to the truth that God has shown to them.

Paragraph 2:7–11

Read 2:7–11 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: These verses show which of God's commands John particularly wanted his readers to obey, namely the command to love our fellow Christians. If we obey that command we are living according to the truth and purity of God's nature, which John calls "the light".

2:10a

Whoever loves his brother remains in the light,

- It is those who love their fellow Christians who are really living in accordance with God's light/purity,

Whoever loves his brother remains in the light:

(Focus) John is not just making a statement here; he is also giving an implied command, "Therefore you should love your fellow Christians." Since this is John's main point in verses 7–11, it may be necessary in translation to draw attention to it with the natural focus markers of your language, or words such as, "Look," or "I tell you."

2:10b

and there is no cause of stumbling in him.

- and there is nothing in their way of life which will make them do wrong.

no cause of stumbling in him: (Alternative Interpretations) There are two interpretations as to who might be caused to sin:

1. The phrase probably means “cause himself to sin.”
2. Some think it means “cause someone else to sin.” (GNT)

stumbling: (Metaphor) This is a common biblical metaphor for committing sin and ceasing to live according to God’s will. In translation a different metaphor with the same meaning may be used, such as, “go astray from God’s way.” Otherwise the meaning “sin” or “do wrong” may be translated directly. See Display.

in him: (Alternative Interpretations) There are two interpretations of the Greek pronoun here:

1. It probably means “in him,” referring to the person who lives in the light.
2. Some think this means “in it,” that is, “in the light.” (RSV)

1 John 2:11

Section 1:5–2:27: Live pure lives and remain united with God

Read 1:5–2:27 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John is appealing to his readers to live morally pure lives and to remain united with God. He gives the following reasons for this:

1:5–2:2	God has made it possible for us to be morally pure just as he is.
2:3–11	We ought to love our fellow Christians as Christ did.
2:12–27	The readers ought not to love the non-Christian world but they should live according to the truth that God has shown to them.

Paragraph 2:7–11

Read 2:7–11 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: These verses show which of God’s commands John particularly wanted his readers to obey, namely the command to love our fellow Christians. If we obey that command we are living according to the truth and purity of God’s nature, which John calls “the light”.

2:11a

But whoever hates his brother is in the darkness

- But anyone who treats a fellow Christian unkindly is living in the darkness of evil and ignorance.

2:11b

and walks in the darkness.

- He does everything without knowing right and wrong,

walks in the darkness: (Metaphor) See the note on 2:6. However, John extends the metaphor in this verse by comparing this person with someone who walks about in a dark place and cannot see where he is going.

2:11c

He does not know where he is going,

- so he does not know what he is doing

where he is going: (Alternative Interpretations) There are two ways of understanding this:

1. As stated in the previous note, it is probably just part of the picture of someone who cannot see where he is going in the dark.
2. Some commentators say it means that the person who hates his brother “does not know he is going to Hell.” But this is unlikely, since John is not concerned with Hell in this letter.

2:11d

because the darkness has blinded his eyes.

- because that evil/ignorance has made him like a blind person.

has blinded his eyes: (Metaphor) Here John extends the metaphor further by comparing this person with someone who has become blind. The meaning is that ignorance or rejection of God’s truth prevents one from knowing what one is really doing.

1 John 2:12

Section 1:5–2:27: Live pure lives and remain united with God

Read 1:5–2:27 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John is appealing to his readers to live morally pure lives and to remain united with God. He gives the following reasons for this:

1:5–2:2	God has made it possible for us to be morally pure just as he is.
2:3–11	We ought to love our fellow Christians as Christ did.
2:12–27	The readers ought not to love the non-Christian world but they should live accord-

	ing to the truth that God has shown to them.
--	--

Paragraph 2:12–14

Read 2:12–14 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Discourse Features: In these verses John breaks off from the main theme of his letter in order to assure his readers that he does not doubt that they are true Christians. To do this he uses a very different style of writing, with much repetition and use of the second person “you.” He also emphasizes his confidence in his readers by repeating in 2:14 much of what he had said in 2:12–13 with some differences. In translation it may be necessary to adjust the style of these verses so that they are clearly understood as an interruption to the main theme and as a reassurance to the readers.

2:12a

I am writing to you, little children,

- ¶ You^(plur) who are like children to me, I am writing these instructions to you

little children: (Alternative Interpretations) There are different interpretations of who this refers to:

1. As in 2:1, little children is probably an affectionate term by which John, an old man, addresses his readers. See the note on 2:1.
2. Some think the phrase little children refers to children or very recent converts among John’s readers.

2:12b

because your sins have been forgiven

- because we^(incl) know that God has forgiven you for your wrong deeds

because: (Logical Relationship) John is not writing to inform his readers that their sins are forgiven. It is because he and they know their sins are forgiven that he is writing to teach them more about being Christians. This applies to each use of “because” in 2:12–14.

have been forgiven: (Passive Construction) If it is necessary to turn this into an active verb, the actor should be stated as “God.” For example, “God has forgiven your sins.”

2:12c

through His name.

- because of what Jesus Christ has done for you.

through His name: (Meaning) This is a common biblical phrase meaning “because of his authority and what he has done.”

His name: (Pronoun Reference) This refers to Christ.

1 John 2:13

Section 1:5–2:27: Live pure lives and remain united with God

Read 1:5–2:27 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John is appealing to his readers to live morally pure lives and to remain united with God. He gives the following reasons for this:

1:5–2:2	God has made it possible for us to be morally pure just as he is.
2:3–11	We ought to love our fellow Christians as Christ did.
2:12–27	The readers ought not to love the non-Christian world but they should live according to the truth that God has shown to them.

Paragraph 2:12–14

Read 2:12–14 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Discourse Features: In these verses John breaks off from the main theme of his letter in order to assure his readers that he does not doubt that they are true Christians. To do this he uses a very different style of writing, with much repetition and use of the second person “you.” He also emphasizes his confidence in his readers by repeating in 2:14 much of what he had said in 2:12–13 with some differences. In translation it may be necessary to adjust the style of these verses so that they are clearly understood as an interruption to the main theme and as a reassurance to the readers.

2:13a

I am writing to you, fathers,

- You senior Christians, I am writing these instructions to you
- I am writing this to you who have trusted Christ for a long time

fathers: (Alternative Interpretations) John is addressing a group among his readers who are in some respect older than the others. Note that they are not “fathers” to John himself, since he is a very old man at the time of writing this letter and this group is included in those he called “my children” in 2:1. However there are two interpretations of how those in this group are older than the other Christians:

1. John probably means those who have been Christians for a longer time.

2. Some think it means those who are older in age.

2:13b

because you know Him

- because we^(incl) know that you have become people who know Jesus Christ,

you know: (Multiple Senses) See the note “to know Him” on 2:3a.

2:13c

who is from the beginning.

- who already existed even before the beginning of this world.

2:13b–c

Him who is from the beginning: (Meaning) This is referring to Jesus Christ, who existed even before the world was created. So it may be necessary to make the name explicit in translation. See also the note on 1:1 “from the beginning.”

2:13d

I am writing to you, young men,

- You new Christians, I am also writing these instructions to you
- I am writing this to you who have just now trusted Christ

young men: (Alternative Interpretations) There are two interpretations of this phrase:

1. It probably means those who have been Christians for a short time.
2. Some think it means men between 20 and 40 years old.

2:13e

because you have overcome the evil one.

- because we^(incl) know that you have defeated Satan, who causes all evil.

the evil one: (Meaning) This is a common way of referring to Satan in the New Testament. The name “Satan” may need to be made explicit here in order to make it clear that the phrase the evil one does not refer to just any evil person.

2:13f

I have written to you, children,

- You who are like children to me, I am writing these instructions to you

I have written: (Alternative Interpretations) In 2:13f and 2:14 the Greek has the past tense, literally, “I wrote,” instead of the present tense, “I am writing,” which it has in 2:12a–13e. There are different views as to whether this change of tense indicates a different meaning or not:

1. It is probably just a matter of style with no difference of meaning. John is continuing to refer to what he is writing in this present letter. (BSB, GNT, RSV, LB)
2. Some think that the past tense indicates that John is referring only to the first part of this letter or to something else which he had written. (JB, NEB, KJV, JBP)

children: (Alternative Interpretations): See the note on 2:12a.

2:13g

because you know the Father.

- because we^(incl) know that you have become people who know God, our^(incl) Father.

the Father: (Expression) In some languages it may be necessary to say “our (incl) Father.”

1 John 2:14

Section 1:5–2:27: Live pure lives and remain united with God

Read 1:5–2:27 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John is appealing to his readers to live morally pure lives and to remain united with God. He gives the following reasons for this:

1:5–2:2	God has made it possible for us to be morally pure just as he is.
2:3–11	We ought to love our fellow Christians as Christ did.
2:12–27	The readers ought not to love the non-Christian world but they should live according to the truth that God has shown to them.

Paragraph 2:12–14

Read 2:12–14 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Discourse Features: In these verses John breaks off from the main theme of his letter in order to assure his readers that he does not doubt that they are true Christians. To do this he uses a very different style of writing, with much repetition and use of the second person “you.” He also emphasizes his confidence in his readers by repeating in 2:14 much of what he had said in 2:12–13 with some differences. In translation it may be necessary to adjust the style of these verses so that they are clearly understood as an interruption to the main theme and as a reassurance to the readers.

2:14a

I have written to you, fathers,

- You senior Christians, I am writing these instructions to you
- I am writing this to you who have trusted Christ for a long time

2:14b

because you know Him

- because we^(incl) know that you have become people who know Jesus Christ

2:14c

who is from the beginning.

- who already existed even before the beginning of this world.

2:14d

I have written to you, young men,

- You new Christians, I am also writing these instructions to you
- I am writing this to you who have just now trusted Christ

2:14g

and you have overcome the evil one.

- and you have defeated Satan, who causes all evil.

2:14 (Verse Number)

Note that GNT, JB and some other versions have the verse number in a different place from KJV, RSV, BSB and others. In translation it may be best to follow the numbering system that is used in the major version in your area.

2:14e

because you are strong,

- because we^(incl) know that you are trusting Christ firmly,

strong: (Metaphor) This refers here to spiritual strength, perseverance in faith, ability to defend and proclaim the gospel.

2:14f

and the word of God abides in you,

- and God’s message is always in your minds,
- and you always pay attention to what God has said,

the word of God abides in you: (Metaphor) This metaphor is showing that the word of God is constantly present in the lives of the readers, so that they are always paying attention to it.

1 John 2:15

Section 1:5–2:27: Live pure lives and remain united with God

Read 1:5–2:27 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John is appealing to his readers to live morally pure lives and to remain united with God. He gives the following reasons for this:

1:5–2:2	God has made it possible for us to be morally pure just as he is.
2:3–11	We ought to love our fellow Christians as Christ did.
2:12–27	The readers ought not to love the non-Christian world but they should live according to the truth that God has shown to them.

Paragraph 2:15–17

Read 2:15–17 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: Here John is appealing to his readers not to love the evil things of this world.

2:15 (Discourse Feature)

In the Greek and English versions there is nothing explicit that connects 2:15–17 and the previous verses. However this paragraph is John’s main appeal, or exhortation, to his readers and it is based on the reassurance he has given them in 2:12–14. In order to make the translation sound natural in your language, you may need to make the connection explicit here by using some joining word or phrase such as “Therefore,” or “So I tell you.”

2:15a

Do not love the world or anything in the world.

- ¶ So I tell you all, do not love bad ways of life and the evil that is in this world.

Do not: (Pronoun Reference) Be sure that you translate this so that it clearly refers to all the readers, not just to the last people mentioned, the “young men” (2:14).

love: (Multiple Senses) This is used here in the sense of desiring to get something, or making something the center of all your interests (NEB “do not set your hearts on...”).

the world: (Multiple Senses) This does not mean “the people in the world,” which is its meaning in John 3:16. Here it is used in the sense of the evil of this world, which is contrary to God’s will. See world in Key Biblical Terms.

anything: (Meaning) John is not referring here to material objects in the world. He is telling his readers to avoid all attitudes and thoughts which belong to this world rather than to God's will. He gives examples of what he means in the next verse.

2:15b

If anyone loves the world, the love of the Father is not in him.

- For whoever loves the evil that is in this world cannot also love our^(incl) Father, God.

If anyone...: (Logical Relationship) This sentence gives one reason for John's appeal not to love the world. The second reason is given in 2:17. To make the connection clear you may need to translate this as "Because/For if anyone..."

the love of the Father: ("of" Construction) Since this is being contrasted with loving the world, it clearly means "he does not love God." It does not mean "God does not love him."

1 John 2:16

Section 1:5–2:27: Live pure lives and remain united with God

Read 1:5–2:27 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John is appealing to his readers to live morally pure lives and to remain united with God. He gives the following reasons for this:

1:5–2:2	God has made it possible for us to be morally pure just as he is.
2:3–11	We ought to love our fellow Christians as Christ did.
2:12–27	The readers ought not to love the non-Christian world but they should live according to the truth that God has shown to them.

Paragraph 2:15–17

Read 2:15–17 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: Here John is appealing to his readers not to love the evil things of this world.

2:16 (Sentence Breaks)

This is a long sentence containing a list of items which may each have to be translated by a whole clause. You may need to make this into two or more sentences in your translation. See the Display.

2:16a

For all that is in the world—

- Those bad ways of life include behavior such as

For all that is in the world: (Logical Relationship) This verse gives the reason for John's statement in the second part of 2:15 that someone who loves the world cannot at the same time be loving God. It is not giving a reason for the appeal not to love the world.

all that is in the world: (Figure of Speech) This is hyperbole, or exaggeration. John means "all the evil ways/deeds of people in this world, such as..." Then in 2:16b–d he gives three specific examples of these evil ways.

2:16b

the desires of the flesh,

- people doing what pleases themselves,

the desires of the flesh: (Meaning) John is here referring to the way our human nature makes us want to do things just for our own pleasure.

the flesh: (Multiple Senses) The word flesh here refers to the human body, so used in the phrase "desires of the flesh" the entire phrase refers to sinful physical desires.

2:16c

the desires of the eyes,

- and people being jealous,
- and seeing things and wanting to have them,

the desires of the eyes: (Meaning) This refers to the way people want to get things they see or hear about, not caring whether God wants them to have those things or not.

2:16d

and the pride of life—

- and being proud of having many things.

the pride of life: (Meaning) This implies the type of pride which is wrong, because the thing you are boasting about is not really yours, or because it is not actually a good thing.

life: (Multiple Senses) The Greek word translated here is used in the sense of possessions, wealth, the means of living.

2:16e

is not from the Father but from the world.

- All this behavior is caused by this evil world; it is not what God our Father has ordered us to do.

is not from: (Metaphor) If it is not natural in your language to speak of attitudes such as desire and pride "coming from" someone or something then you may need to translate the meaning directly. See the Dis-

play. The basic meaning here is that these attitudes are not ones God wants us to have, but rather they are caused by our following the evil ways of the world.

1 John 2:17

Section 1:5–2:27: Live pure lives and remain united with God

Read 1:5–2:27 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John is appealing to his readers to live morally pure lives and to remain united with God. He gives the following reasons for this:

1:5–2:2	God has made it possible for us to be morally pure just as he is.
2:3–11	We ought to love our fellow Christians as Christ did.
2:12–27	The readers ought not to love the non-Christian world but they should live according to the truth that God has shown to them.

Paragraph 2:15–17

Read 2:15–17 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: Here John is appealing to his readers not to love the evil things of this world.

2:17a

The world is passing away, along with its desires;

- Also this evil world will soon cease to exist, and so this evil behavior will stop.
- God has begun to destroy this evil world, and so these bad ways of living will not continue for ever.

(RSV:) And: (Logical Relationship) 2:17 gives a second reason for the appeal in 2:15 not to love the world. It is therefore connected in meaning to 2:15b. It does not follow in meaning from 2:16.

is passing away: (Meaning) John is telling his readers that this world will not last much longer. When Jesus returns to judge the world everything that is evil will be destroyed. The verb is in the present tense here because Jesus is already at work in the world, so the evil is already being destroyed.

its desires: (Meaning) This refers to all the evil ways of the world, such as the wrong attitudes mentioned in 2:16.

2:17b

but whoever does the will of God remains forever.

- But anyone who obeys God will never stop living.

whoever: (Meaning) As in 2:4, this means “anyone who.” It could also be translated “if anyone,” or “if you.”

does: (Tense) The tense here indicates continuous action, not just doing God’s will once.

1 John 2:18

Section 1:5–2:27: Live pure lives and remain united with God

Read 1:5–2:27 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John is appealing to his readers to live morally pure lives and to remain united with God. He gives the following reasons for this:

1:5–2:2	God has made it possible for us to be morally pure just as he is.
2:3–11	We ought to love our fellow Christians as Christ did.
2:12–27	The readers ought not to love the non-Christian world but they should live according to the truth that God has shown to them.

Paragraph 2:18–21

Read 2:18–21 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: In these verses John reassures his readers that they have received the Holy Spirit, and so they know God’s truth. In this way they are different from the false teachers.

2:18a

Children, it is the last hour;

- ¶ You^(plur) who are like children to me, I tell you that these are the last days of this world.
- ¶ My children, the time when this world will finish has come near.

Children: (Cross-cultural Difference) Here, as in 2:1, John is writing as a respected leader to churches for which he is responsible. He is showing fatherly affection.

the last hour: (Meaning) John is saying that the time when the world will come to an end is no longer distant and that we are in the last period of the world’s time. As this is a metaphorical use of the word “hour” it may be more natural in your language to translate it as “the last days” or “the time when the world is about to end.”

2:18b

and just as you have heard that

- Remember that in the past we^(excl) told you that

you have heard: (Lexical Problem) In some languages it may be necessary to state who told them this. In that case it should be expressed as indefinite, “One told you,” or as “We (John and the other apostles) told you.”

2:18c

the antichrist is coming,

- in the last days of this world a well-known enemy of Christ will appear.

the antichrist: (Biblical Term) See under Christ in Key Biblical Terms. In this letter John uses this term in the sense of a person who is opposed to Christ, “the enemy of Christ.”

is coming: (Meaning) This means that the antichrist will appear in the world, not that he will come from some other place.

2:18d

so now many antichrists have appeared.

- So just as we told you, you now see that many enemies of Christ have appeared.

so now many antichrists have appeared: (Focus) John is not telling his readers this as if they did not know it. He is reminding his readers of what they already know—that there are many false teachers about. He does this in order to prove that they really are in the last days of the world and therefore they do need to hold on firmly to God’s word.

2:18e

This is how we know it is the last hour.

- Because of this we^(incl) know that indeed these are the last days of this world.
- This shows us that truly the time when the world will finish has come near.

This is how we know: (Pronoun Reference) The word this refers to the fact that many antichrists have appeared.

1 John 2:19

Section 1:5–2:27: Live pure lives and remain united with God

Read 1:5–2:27 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John is appealing to his readers to live morally pure lives and to remain united with God. He gives the following reasons for this:

1:5–2:2	God has made it possible for us to be morally pure just as he is.
---------	---

2:3–11	We ought to love our fellow Christians as Christ did.
2:12–27	The readers ought not to love the non-Christian world but they should live according to the truth that God has shown to them.

Paragraph 2:18–21

Read 2:18–21 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: In these verses John reassures his readers that they have received the Holy Spirit, and so they know God’s truth. In this way they are different from the false teachers.

2:19a

They went out from us,

- These enemies of Christ used to be in our^(incl) churches/fellowship, and now they have left.

They went out from us: (Meaning) These people whom John has just called “antichrists” had originally been members of the church. Then they disagreed with the other members over whether Jesus was the Christ whom God sent from heaven, and so they left the church. This proved that they had never really been true Christians (2:19d).

2:19b

but they did not belong to us.

- But they were never true Christians like us.^(incl)

they did not belong to us: (Meaning) John means that those people had never really been members of the group of believers. They were never true Christians like himself and his readers.

2:19c

For if they had belonged to us, they would have remained with us.

- If they had really been our^(incl) fellow Christians, they would have stayed in our churches/fellowship.

2:19d

But their departure made it clear that none of them belonged to us.

- God caused them to leave us in order to show that none of them were our fellow Christians.

(GNT:) they left so that...: (Meaning) John is not saying that these people left the church with the purpose in their minds of showing that they were not really Christians. Rather he is saying that God’s purpose in their leaving was that it should have the effect of

making clear that they were not Christians. See BSB, NIV, JBP, LB.

1 John 2:20

Section 1:5–2:27: Live pure lives and remain united with God

Read 1:5–2:27 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John is appealing to his readers to live morally pure lives and to remain united with God. He gives the following reasons for this:

1:5–2:2	God has made it possible for us to be morally pure just as he is.
2:3–11	We ought to love our fellow Christians as Christ did.
2:12–27	The readers ought not to love the non-Christian world but they should live according to the truth that God has shown to them.

Paragraph 2:18–21

Read 2:18–21 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: In these verses John reassures his readers that they have received the Holy Spirit, and so they know God's truth. In this way they are different from the false teachers.

2:20a

You, however, have an anointing from the Holy One,

- But as for you,^(plur) Christ has given you the Holy Spirit,

You, however: (Emphasis) This is contrasting the readers with the people who had left the church.

have an anointing from the Holy One: (Alternative Interpretations) See anoint in Key Biblical Terms. This is a metaphor comparing something to the Jewish practice of anointing men with oil when they became priests. There are different views about what topic is being compared:

1. John is probably referring to Christ giving the Holy Spirit to those who truly become Christians. (GNT, LB)
2. Some think it refers to God giving his word. (JBP)
3. Others think it refers to God making Christians special people, like priests. (NEB)

the Holy One: (Alternative Interpretations) See holy in Key Biblical Terms. There are different views as to who the phrase the Holy One refers to here:

1. It probably refers to Christ, as it does elsewhere in the New Testament. (GNT)
2. Some think it refers to God, as it does in the Old Testament. (JBP)

2:20b

and all of you know the truth.

- and so you all know the true things which God has revealed.

and all of you know: (Text) The KJV reading “ye know all things” is from an inferior Greek text.

know the truth: (Expression) The Greek here is literally, “you know.” No object is expressed, so the meaning is “you have knowledge,” “you are no longer ignorant.” However in many languages, including English, this leaves it unclear what sort of knowledge is meant. Many translations therefore specify, know the truth (BSB, NIV, GNT, LB) since that is the sort of knowledge John talks about in the next verse.

1 John 2:21

Section 1:5–2:27: Live pure lives and remain united with God

Read 1:5–2:27 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John is appealing to his readers to live morally pure lives and to remain united with God. He gives the following reasons for this:

1:5–2:2	God has made it possible for us to be morally pure just as he is.
2:3–11	We ought to love our fellow Christians as Christ did.
2:12–27	The readers ought not to love the non-Christian world but they should live according to the truth that God has shown to them.

Paragraph 2:18–21

Read 2:18–21 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: In these verses John reassures his readers that they have received the Holy Spirit, and so they know God's truth. In this way they are different from the false teachers.

2:21a

I have not written to you because you lack knowledge of the truth,

- So the reason why I am writing this letter to you is not that I think you are people who do not know the truth.

(GNT:) then: (Logical Relationship) Having stated that his readers have knowledge, John points out that this shows he is confident of their true faith in Christ (as in 2:12-14). GNT and LB make this connection explicit.

I have not written to you because you lack knowledge of: (Sentence Breaks) John is telling his readers not to think that the reason for his writing to them is that he considers them ignorant of the truth. Notice that this statement contains two negatives, which may make it unclear in translation. It may therefore be better to make it a separate sentence from 2:21b-c and make the reasoning more explicit. See the Display. Or it could be translated using a rhetorical question:

Am I writing to you because I think that you do not know the truth? No. It is not because of that. I am sure that you know the truth.

2:21b
but because you have it,

- No, the reason that I am writing to you is because you do indeed know the true things which God has revealed,

2:21b-c
(RSV:) because you know it, and you know that...: (Alternative Interpretations) There are different interpretations as to how 2:21b and 2:21c relate to each other:

1. John is probably saying that his readers know two things, firstly, the truth, and secondly, that no lie comes from it. (KJV, RSV, GNT, JB)
2. Some think he is only mentioning one thing they know (the truth) and then he gives another reason for his writing, namely that no lie comes from the truth. (BSB, NEB)

2:21c
and because no lie comes from the truth.

- and because you know that no false teachings are part of the true things which God has revealed.

comes from: (Metaphor) To say that a lie comes from something abstract like truth is a metaphor, which may not be natural in your language. The basic meaning to be translated here is that truth and lies are totally different, so it is impossible for wrong beliefs (lies) to be part of God's truth.

1 John 2:22

Section 1:5-2:27: Live pure lives and remain united with God

Read 1:5-2:27 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John is appealing to his readers to live morally pure lives and to remain united with God. He gives the following reasons for this:

1:5-2:2	God has made it possible for us to be morally pure just as he is.
2:3-11	We ought to love our fellow Christians as Christ did.
2:12-27	The readers ought not to love the non-Christian world but they should live according to the truth that God has shown to them.

Paragraph 2:22-25

Read 2:22-25 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: On the basis of the reassurance he has just given in 2:18-21, John here urges his readers to reject false teaching and to live according to God's truth.

2:22a

Who is the liar, if it is not the one who denies that Jesus is the Christ?

- ¶ I tell you,^(plur) the very worst sort of liar is anyone who says that Jesus is not the Christ/Messiah who God sent to this world.

Who is the liar: (Rhetorical Question) This is a rhetorical question used for emphasis. John is stating emphatically that the worst possible lie is that Jesus was not the Christ. This is what those people who had left the church were teaching. In your translation you may need to turn this into an emphatic statement, as JB has done. See the Display.

the one who: (Meaning) This is not referring to a particular man but rather to anyone or everyone who denies that Jesus is the Christ.

the Christ: (Biblical Term) Here Christ is not just a name. It is the title or description of the one who God would send from heaven to save and rule his people. It is the same as the title "Messiah." See Christ in Key Biblical Terms.

2:22b

This is the antichrist, who denies the Father and the Son.

- When such a person says that Jesus is not the Christ, he is rejecting God the Father together with Jesus, God's Son. So it is clear that such a person is just like that well-known enemy of Christ.

This is the antichrist: (Logical Relationship) John is saying that if someone denies that Jesus is the Christ,

he is making himself an enemy of Christ just like that enemy of Christ who will come at the end of the world. See Christ in Key Biblical Terms.

who denies the Father...: (Logical Relationship) This shows how we know that such a person is the enemy of Christ. When he denies that Jesus is the Christ he is also denying that Jesus is God's son, and so he is rejecting God the Father also.

denies: (Multiple Senses) In the first use of denies in this verse ("denies that Jesus is the Christ"), it means he "says that it is not true that Jesus is the Christ." In 2:22b ("he denies the Father and the Son"), it means he "refuses to accept the Father and the Son." It is used again in this sense in the next verse.

1 John 2:23

Section 1:5–2:27: Live pure lives and remain united with God

Read 1:5–2:27 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John is appealing to his readers to live morally pure lives and to remain united with God. He gives the following reasons for this:

1:5–2:2	God has made it possible for us to be morally pure just as he is.
2:3–11	We ought to love our fellow Christians as Christ did.
2:12–27	The readers ought not to love the non-Christian world but they should live according to the truth that God has shown to them.

Paragraph 2:22–25

Read 2:22–25 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: On the basis of the reassurance he has just given in 2:18–21, John here urges his readers to reject false teaching and to live according to God's truth.

2:23 (Emphasis)

In this verse John is making it clear that our relationship to God depends on our believing in Jesus. He emphasizes this by stating it first negatively and then positively.

2:23a

Whoever denies the Son does not have the Father,

- This is clear because if anyone rejects the Son of God, it is impossible for that person to be united with God the Father.

have the Father: (Meaning) This is another way by which John refers to Christians' close relationship and union with God the Father. See also the note on 2:5c "in Him."

2:23b

but whoever confesses the Son has the Father as well.

- But anyone who accepts the Son of God accepts God the Father also.
- But if anyone says openly that Jesus is the Son of God, he is united with God the Father also.

confesses the Son: (Meaning) This is the opposite of "denies the Son." It means "accepts, says openly that he believes in Jesus as the Son of God."

1 John 2:24

Section 1:5–2:27: Live pure lives and remain united with God

Read 1:5–2:27 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John is appealing to his readers to live morally pure lives and to remain united with God. He gives the following reasons for this:

1:5–2:2	God has made it possible for us to be morally pure just as he is.
2:3–11	We ought to love our fellow Christians as Christ did.
2:12–27	The readers ought not to love the non-Christian world but they should live according to the truth that God has shown to them.

Paragraph 2:22–25

Read 2:22–25 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: On the basis of the reassurance he has just given in 2:18–21, John here urges his readers to reject false teaching and to live according to God's truth.

2:24a

As for you, let what you have heard from the beginning remain in you.

- So I say to you, keep always in your minds the message about Christ which you have heard from the time when you began to follow Christ.
- Therefore you must always pay attention to the teaching about Christ which you have known since the first time you heard the gospel.

As for you, let: (Discourse Feature) This instruction (2:24a) is the main thing John is saying in 2:18–25. He has warned his readers about the false teaching of those who have left the church, so he tells them they must therefore be careful not to forget or change the true Christian teaching they have received. The strong imperative is shown in several English versions by the phrases “See that” (NIV), “Be sure” (GNT), “You must” (NEB).

from the beginning: (Meaning) As in 2:7b, this refers to the time when they first became Christians. This meaning of from the beginning is different from the meaning of the same phrase in 1:1 and 2:13c.

remain in you: (Meaning) In the Greek this phrase has the same meaning as the phrase “abides in you” in 2:14f. See the note on 2:14f.

2:24b

If it does, you will also remain in the Son and in the Father.

- For if you let that message always remain in your minds, you, for your part, will always remain united with the Son of God and with God the Father.
- Because, if you continue to pay attention to that teaching, you will also continue to be in close fellowship with Jesus, God’s Son, and with God, his Father.

If it does: (Ellipsis) This is a short way in English of referring to what has just been said. See GNT and NEB for ways of saying it more fully.

you will also: (Meaning) This means “you for your part will.” John is contrasting his readers (who remain in the Son) with the teaching (which remains in them). It does not mean “you in addition to others will.”

in the Son and in the Father: (Collocation) As in 2:5 this is John’s way of talking about our close personal relationship and union with God. See the note on “in Him” in 2:5c.

1 John 2:25

Section 1:5–2:27: Live pure lives and remain united with God

Read 1:5–2:27 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John is appealing to his readers to live morally pure lives and to remain united with God. He gives the following reasons for this:

1:5–2:2	God has made it possible for us to be morally pure just as he is.
---------	---

2:3–11	We ought to love our fellow Christians as Christ did.
2:12–27	The readers ought not to love the non-Christian world but they should live according to the truth that God has shown to them.

Paragraph 2:22–25

Read 2:22–25 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: On the basis of the reassurance he has just given in 2:18–21, John here urges his readers to reject false teaching and to live according to God’s truth.

2:25

And this is the promise that He Himself made to us: eternal life.

- If we^(incl) remain united with God like that, we have received the eternal heavenly life which Christ promised to give us.

this: (Pronoun Reference) The pronoun this refers back to the idea of remaining in the Son and in the Father.

He: (Pronoun Reference) The Greek pronoun translated He clearly refers to Jesus here.

to us: (Text) Some Greek manuscripts have “you.” This is what JB translates. But the best manuscripts have to us. It is recommended that you translate “to us” here.

eternal life: (Logical Relationship) John is saying that if we remain in the Son and in the Father, then we have the eternal life which Jesus promised. See JBP.

eternal life: (Special Biblical Term) Just as in other places in the New Testament where this term is used, it describes the heavenly life which God himself has and which he gives to us. See the note on 1:2d.

1 John 2:26

Section 1:5–2:27: Live pure lives and remain united with God

Read 1:5–2:27 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John is appealing to his readers to live morally pure lives and to remain united with God. He gives the following reasons for this:

1:5–2:2	God has made it possible for us to be morally pure just as he is.
2:3–11	We ought to love our fellow Christians as Christ did.

2:12-27	The readers ought not to love the non-Christian world but they should live according to the truth that God has shown to them.
---------	---

Paragraph 2:26-27

Read 2:26-27 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: John finishes this section by repeating his appeal to his readers to live according to the truth which they have been taught and to remain in union with Christ. This is a summary of the section 1:5-2:27.

2:26a

I have written these things to you

- ¶ I am warning you^(plur)

these things: (Pronoun Reference) This refers to what John has written in 2:18-25.

2:26b

about those who are trying to deceive you.

- that those people who left the churches are trying to deceive you with false teaching about the gospel.

about those who: (Meaning) John was not just writing about these people, he was warning his readers against them.

deceive you: (Meaning) Those who had left the church were trying to deceive the Christians with false teachings about the gospel.

1 John 2:27

Section 1:5-2:27: Live pure lives and remain united with God

Read 1:5-2:27 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John is appealing to his readers to live morally pure lives and to remain united with God. He gives the following reasons for this:

1:5-2:2	God has made it possible for us to be morally pure just as he is.
2:3-11	We ought to love our fellow Christians as Christ did.
2:12-27	The readers ought not to love the non-Christian world but they should live according to the truth that God has shown to them.

Paragraph 2:26-27

Read 2:26-27 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: John finishes this section by repeating his appeal to his readers to live according to the truth which they have been taught and to remain in union with Christ. This is a summary of the section 1:5-2:27.

2:27a

And as for you, the anointing you received from Him remains in you,

- But as for you, you will not be deceived because Christ has given you the Holy Spirit, and the Holy Spirit is still in you.

And as for you: (Emphasis) John is emphasizing here that the Christians, who knew the truth because they had the Holy Spirit in them, are different from the false teachers, who had wrong ideas.

the anointing you received from Him: (Alternative Interpretations) This probably refers to Christ giving the Holy Spirit. See the note on 2:20a on “an anointing from the Holy One.”

2:27b

and you do not need anyone to teach you.

- Therefore it is not necessary for any other person/teacher to instruct you about the true things which God has revealed.

and you do not need: (Logical Connection) This gives the result of the previous statement, so it may need to be linked by “so” or “therefore.” See Display. In some languages the clauses in 2:27a-b may need to be reversed. For example:

As for you, you do not need anyone to teach you, because/since the anointing you received from him remains in you.

you do not need anyone to teach you: (Figure of Speech) This is hyperbole, a deliberate exaggeration. What John says is stronger than what he means. He certainly thought that his readers needed some teaching because this whole letter is full of teaching. His meaning is that they do not need any teaching other than that which is from the Holy Spirit. If you cannot use hyperbole in this way in your language, you could say “you do not need any other teacher” in order to make the meaning clear. See the Display.

to teach you: (Background Information) The teaching would be about God’s truth.

2:27c

But just as His true and genuine anointing teaches you about all things,

- Instead of that, the Holy Spirit, who Christ has given to you, is causing you to know all the truth about those things. And what the Holy Spirit teaches you is entirely true without any falsehood in it.

His true and genuine anointing: (Alternative Interpretations)

1. This probably means that what the Holy Spirit teaches is true. (BSB, GNT, KJV, LB, JBP)
2. It may mean that the readers have really received the Holy Spirit. (NIV, NEB)

true and genuine: (Emphasis) In Greek this phrase is literally “is true and is not a lie.” John is here using repetition, first positive and then negative, for emphasis. If this sort of repetition is not natural in your language, you will need to use some other way of expressing the emphasis. The BSB expresses the emphasis by expressing a positive idea two times.

about all things: (Figure of Speech) Again John is using hyperbole. He is emphasizing that the Holy Spirit teaches them about all those true things God has revealed which they need to know. See Display on 2:27b–c.

2:27d

so remain in Him as you have been taught.

- Therefore I say to you, remain united with Christ just as the Holy Spirit has told you to do.

in Him: (Collocation) See the note on 2:5c.

Him: (Pronoun Reference) This refers to Christ.

have been taught: (Meaning) The Holy Spirit is the one who has taught the Christians.

1 John 2:28

Section 2:28–4:6: We should obey God’s commands in order to avoid being ashamed when we meet Christ

Read 2:28–4:6 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section (after the main theme in 2:28–29), John is saying that in order not to be ashamed when we meet Christ we must do the following:

3:1–10	We should live pure and righteous lives as Christ did.
3:11–18	We should love and help our fellow Christians.
3:19–24	We should obey God’s commands to believe in his Son and to love one another.

4:1–6	We should carefully test what teachers say so that we know whether they are speaking for the Holy Spirit.
-------	---

Paragraph 2:28–29

Read 2:28–29 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: These verses give the main theme of Section 2:28–4:6. John says that in order not to be ashamed when Christ returns we must remain in union with him and do what is right.

2:28a

And now, little children, remain in Christ,

- ¶ Therefore, my children, I say to you again, continue to remain united with Christ,

now: (Multiple Senses) The Greek word here is not being used in the sense of “at this time.” It means “therefore/so.” John is repeating his instruction from the previous verse, “continue in Christ,” and going on to state one purpose for doing this.

2:28b

so that when He appears,

- so that at the time when he comes back to this world from heaven

when He appears: (Background Information) This refers to Christ returning to earth from heaven at some time in the future.

2:28c

we may be confident and unashamed before Him at His coming.

- we^(incl) may not be afraid or ashamed to meet him.

confident and unashamed before Him: (Meaning) John means that he and his readers could meet Jesus face to face without being ashamed or afraid. They would have this confidence if they have been living righteous lives in fellowship with Jesus by the help of the Holy Spirit.

confident and unashamed: (Emphasis) Here again John uses a positive-negative repetition for emphasis.

at His coming: (Meaning) This means the same as “when He appears” in 2:28b. If it is not natural in your language to repeat the meaning like this, it can be omitted. See the Display.

1 John 2:29

Section 2:28–4:6: We should obey God’s commands in order to avoid being ashamed when we meet Christ

Read 2:28–4:6 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section (after the main theme in 2:28–29), John is saying that in order not to be ashamed when we meet Christ we must do the following:

3:1–10	We should live pure and righteous lives as Christ did.
3:11–18	We should love and help our fellow Christians.
3:19–24	We should obey God’s commands to believe in his Son and to love one another.
4:1–6	We should carefully test what teachers say so that we know whether they are speaking for the Holy Spirit.

Paragraph 2:28–29

Read 2:28–29 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: These verses give the main theme of Section 2:28–4:6. John says that in order not to be ashamed when Christ returns we must remain in union with him and do what is right.

2:29a

If you know that He is righteous,

- You^(plur) know that Christ does what is good in God’s sight.

If: (Multiple Senses) This does not express doubt. It indicates that the statement “you know that He is righteous” is the reason for what John says in 2:29b. It may be better translated “since” or “because.” Alternatively, the sentence may be translated:

“You know that he is righteous, therefore/so you should recognize that...”

See GNT, JB, LB, JBP.

He is righteous: (Alternative Interpretations) There are different views about who the pronoun He refers to:

1. It probably refers to Christ. (GNT)
2. It may refer to God. (JB, LB, JBP)

righteous: (Multiple Senses) This means that everything that Christ does is right in God’s sight. See the word just in Key Biblical Terms.

2:29b

you also know that everyone who practices righteousness has been born of Him.

- Therefore you should also know that when anyone of you does what is good in God’s sight it shows that he is one of God’s children.

everyone who: (Meaning) John is concerned in this section with the importance of Christians doing what is right. So when he refers to “everyone” here he means “every Christian.” He is not saying that just anybody, even a non-Christian, who does what is right is born of God. He is saying that when Christians do right this shows us that we are God’s children.

righteousness: (Biblical Term) The Greek word used here refers to everything that is in accordance with God’s will. See the word just in Key Biblical Terms.

born of Him: (Pronoun Reference) This certainly means that such a person is the child of God, not of Christ. But this may not be clear unless “God” is made explicit here. See GNT, JBP.

1 John 3:1

Section 2:28–4:6: We should obey God’s commands in order to avoid being ashamed when we meet Christ

Read 2:28–4:6 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section (after the main theme in 2:28–29), John is saying that in order not to be ashamed when we meet Christ we must do the following:

3:1–10	We should live pure and righteous lives as Christ did.
3:11–18	We should love and help our fellow Christians.
3:19–24	We should obey God’s commands to believe in his Son and to love one another.
4:1–6	We should carefully test what teachers say so that we know whether they are speaking for the Holy Spirit.

Paragraph 3:1–3

Read 3:1–3 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: John is saying that we should be living pure lives now because when Christ returns we will be pure like him.

3:1a-b

the Father has given to us, that we should be called children of God: (Lexical Problem) These two terms, the Father and God, refer to the same person. In some languages it may be unnatural or confusing to have one person referred to in two different ways in the same sentence. If that is the case in your language you may need to translate the first reference as “God our Father,” and the second as “his children.” See the Display.

3:1a

Behold what manner of love the Father has given to us,

- ¶ Think/See, God our Father has loved us^(incl) very much indeed.
- ¶ Remember what God the Father has done for us by his great love.

Behold what manner of love: (Parenthesis) The first half of this verse is an exclamation. It interrupts the teaching about doing what is right. John just mentioned in 2:29 that we are God’s children, and now he exclaims that this shows how great God’s love for us is. In translation it is important to make it clear that this is an exclamation and that it is focusing on the greatness of God’s love.

3:1b

that we should be called children of God.

- He loves us so much that he even says about us that we are his children.

that we should be called: (Meaning) This indicates the result of the greatness of God’s love, not his purpose in loving us. See the Display.

be called: (Passive Construction) In translation it may be necessary to turn this into an active verb. The subject is “God” or “he.”

3:1c

And that is what we are!

- And we really have become God’s children in fact.

And that is what we are!: (Parenthesis) John ends his exclamation by saying that in addition to being called God’s children, that is also what we have really become. It is not just a name that God calls us by.

3:1d

The reason the world does not know us is that it did not know Him.

- But the reason why the people of this world do not understand that we are God’s children is that they do not know God our Father.

the world: (Multiple Senses) This phrase is used here in a slightly different sense from how it was used in 2:15. Here it means those people who want the things of the world instead of wanting to do God’s will. See world in Key Biblical Terms.

does not know us: (Meaning) John means that the people of the world do not recognize or accept that we have become children of God.

it did not know Him: (Alternative Interpretations) There are different views about who this refers to:

1. John is writing here about our relationship to God, so it probably means that the people did not know or believe in God.
2. Some think it means that the people did not recognize who Christ was. (JBP)

1 John 3:2

Section 2:28–4:6: We should obey God’s commands in order to avoid being ashamed when we meet Christ

Read 2:28–4:6 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section (after the main theme in 2:28–29), John is saying that in order not to be ashamed when we meet Christ we must do the following:

3:1–10	We should live pure and righteous lives as Christ did.
3:11–18	We should love and help our fellow Christians.
3:19–24	We should obey God’s commands to believe in his Son and to love one another.
4:1–6	We should carefully test what teachers say so that we know whether they are speaking for the Holy Spirit.

Paragraph 3:1–3

Read 3:1–3 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: John is saying that we should be living pure lives now because when Christ returns we will be pure like him.

3:2a

Beloved, we are now children of God,

- So, my dear people, at the present time we see that we^(incl) are God’s children.

Beloved: (Meaning) As in 2:7, this indicates John's loving attitude towards his readers. See the note on 2:7a.

3:2b and what we will be has not yet been revealed.

- We do not yet know what we will be like in the future.
- God has not yet shown us how he intends to change us.

what we will be: (Meaning) John is not saying that we will stop being children of God and become something else. He is expecting that as God gives us his glory we will be changed, although John does not fully know what our changed state will be.

3:2c We know that when Christ appears,

- But we^(incl) do know certainly that when Christ returns to this world

when Christ appears: (Alternative Interpretations) In the Greek the subject of the verb is not expressed explicitly. This phrase in Greek is literally "when he appears." There are two views about what the subject is and what the verb means:

1. The subject is probably Christ, so the verb means "he appears." As in 2:28, it refers to Christ returning to earth from heaven at some time in the future. (BSB, GNT, NIV, RSV, KJV, LB, JBP)
2. Some think the subject is "what we will be," so the verb means "it is made known." (JB, NEB)

3:2d we will be like Him, for we will see Him as He is.

- we will see what he really is, and so we will become like him.

for we will see...: (Alternative Interpretations) There are two views about how this clause is linked to the rest of the sentence:

1. It is probably giving the reason for our being like Christ. See LB. As Paul teaches in 2 Corinthians 3:18, the more we see Christ and know him the more the Holy Spirit is able to change us to be like him.
2. Some think it is showing how we know that we will be like him.

as He is: (Emphasis) This is emphasizing that we will see Christ not unclearly or partially, but fully and truly. (See GNT, JB, LB)

1 John 3:3

Section 2:28–4:6: We should obey God's commands in order to avoid being ashamed when we meet Christ

Read 2:28–4:6 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section (after the main theme in 2:28–29), John is saying that in order not to be ashamed when we meet Christ we must do the following:

3:1–10	We should live pure and righteous lives as Christ did.
3:11–18	We should love and help our fellow Christians.
3:19–24	We should obey God's commands to believe in his Son and to love one another.
4:1–6	We should carefully test what teachers say so that we know whether they are speaking for the Holy Spirit.

Paragraph 3:1–3

Read 3:1–3 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: John is saying that we should be living pure lives now because when Christ returns we will be pure like him.

3:3a And everyone who has this hope in Him

- So every one of you who is expecting that he will become like Christ

this hope in Him: (Pronoun Reference) This refers to the expectation of becoming like Christ as mentioned in the last verse.

hope: (Biblical Term) In the New Testament this means "to look forward eagerly to something which you are certain will happen." This is different from the common use of "hope" in modern English, where it means "to be unsure about whether something will happen which you are looking forward to."

3:3b purifies himself, just as Christ is pure.

- ought to keep himself free from sin, just as Christ does not sin.

purifies himself: (Logical Relationship) Because of the way John connects his statements here, this has the force of an exhortation, "he should purify himself." See JB, LB.

purifies: (Tense) The Greek tense here indicates a continuous process of keeping oneself free from sin, rather than a single act of purification.

1 John 3:4

Section 2:28–4:6: We should obey God’s commands in order to avoid being ashamed when we meet Christ

Read 2:28–4:6 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section (after the main theme in 2:28–29), John is saying that in order not to be ashamed when we meet Christ we must do the following:

3:1–10	We should live pure and righteous lives as Christ did.
3:11–18	We should love and help our fellow Christians.
3:19–24	We should obey God’s commands to believe in his Son and to love one another.
4:1–6	We should carefully test what teachers say so that we know whether they are speaking for the Holy Spirit.

Paragraph 3:4–6

Read 3:4–6 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: These verses show that it is impossible to continue sinning and at the same time remain in union with Christ.

3:4a

Everyone who practices sin practices lawlessness as well.

- ¶ Anyone who continually sins is rebelling against the laws of God.
- ¶ When a person continues to do what is wrong in God’s sight he is rejecting God and his laws.

who practices sin: (Tense) The tense shows that John is here referring to continual or habitual sinning.

lawlessness: (Alternative Interpretations) The Greek word used here is the same as that for “lawlessness” in the second part of this verse. (See the next note.) There are two views of its meaning here:

1. It probably means “rejects the authority of God’s law, rebels against God.” (RSV, LB)
2. Some think it means “disobeys God’s law.” (GNT, JB, KJV, JBP)

3:4b

Indeed, sin is lawlessness.

- That is what sin is, it is a rebellion against God’s laws.
- For doing what is wrong is the same as rejecting God and his laws.

lawlessness: (Emotive Impact) The Greek word here is a very strong word. It indicates the sort of terrible rebellion against God that no one would want to be accused of. This effect should be kept in your translation.

1 John 3:5

Section 2:28–4:6: We should obey God’s commands in order to avoid being ashamed when we meet Christ

Read 2:28–4:6 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section (after the main theme in 2:28–29), John is saying that in order not to be ashamed when we meet Christ we must do the following:

3:1–10	We should live pure and righteous lives as Christ did.
3:11–18	We should love and help our fellow Christians.
3:19–24	We should obey God’s commands to believe in his Son and to love one another.
4:1–6	We should carefully test what teachers say so that we know whether they are speaking for the Holy Spirit.

Paragraph 3:4–6

Read 3:4–6 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: These verses show that it is impossible to continue sinning and at the same time remain in union with Christ.

3:5a

But you know that Christ appeared to take away sins,

- You know well that the purpose for which Jesus Christ came to this world was in order to take from us^(incl) the punishment for the sins which we do.

Christ appeared: (Meaning) The meaning here is similar to that of “He appears” in 2:28, but here in 3:5a it refers to when Christ first came into the world.

take away sins: (Meaning) This has the same meaning as in John 1:29, “the Lamb of God who takes away the sin of the world.” It is saying that Jesus died so that

God would forgive our sins and no guilt for them would remain.

3:5b and in Him there is no sin.

- And you know that he never does anything which is in any way sinful/evil.

in Him there is no sin: (Collocation) If it is not possible in your translation to refer to sin being “in” someone, this can be rephrased, “he/Jesus cannot do any sin.”

1 John 3:6

Section 2:28–4:6: We should obey God’s commands in order to avoid being ashamed when we meet Christ

Read 2:28–4:6 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section (after the main theme in 2:28–29), John is saying that in order not to be ashamed when we meet Christ we must do the following:

3:1–10	We should live pure and righteous lives as Christ did.
3:11–18	We should love and help our fellow Christians.
3:19–24	We should obey God’s commands to believe in his Son and to love one another.
4:1–6	We should carefully test what teachers say so that we know whether they are speaking for the Holy Spirit.

Paragraph 3:4–6

Read 3:4–6 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: These verses show that it is impossible to continue sinning and at the same time remain in union with Christ.

3:6 (Logical Relationship)

This verse is the conclusion which John draws from what he has said in 3:4–5. This connection may need to be made clear by a joining word such as “so/therefore” (GNT, NEB, LB). See the Display.

3:6a

No one who remains in Him keeps on sinning.

- Therefore it is clear that when a person remains united with Christ, he ought not to sin continually.

keeps on sinning: (Alternative Interpretations) There are different interpretations of the tense of the Greek verb used here:

1. It probably means “should not be continually/habitually sinning.” (BSB, NIV, GNT, LB, JBP)
2. Some think it means “should not commit any sin.” (JB, RSV, KJV)

in Him: (Collocation) As in 2:5, this is John’s way of talking about a close personal relationship and union with God. See the note on 2:5c.

3:6b

No one who continues to sin

- But if a person is continually sinning

continues to sin: (Meaning) This means the same as “keeps on sinning” in 3:6a.

3:6c

has seen Him or known Him.

- it is clear that he does not understand who Christ is, and he does not know Christ at all.

seen: (Metaphor) This does not refer to literal “seeing,” since most Christians have never seen Christ with their eyes. It is a metaphor for understanding or recognizing Christ for who he is, the Son of God.

1 John 3:7

Section 2:28–4:6: We should obey God’s commands in order to avoid being ashamed when we meet Christ

Read 2:28–4:6 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section (after the main theme in 2:28–29), John is saying that in order not to be ashamed when we meet Christ we must do the following:

3:1–10	We should live pure and righteous lives as Christ did.
3:11–18	We should love and help our fellow Christians.
3:19–24	We should obey God’s commands to believe in his Son and to love one another.
4:1–6	We should carefully test what teachers say so that we know whether they are speaking for the Holy Spirit.

Paragraph 3:7–10

Read 3:7–10 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: John explains that our behavior shows whether we belong to God or to Satan.

3:7a

Little children, let no one deceive you:

- ¶ My children, be careful so that nobody may deceive you

deceive you: (Logical Relationship) This is not a general warning about being deceived. John is specifically warning his readers not to be deceived about the question (in the next part of the verse) of who is really righteous. The two parts of the verse may therefore need to be linked together. See the Display.

3:7b

The one who practices righteousness is righteous,

- about the fact that the only people who are good in God's sight are those who do what God says is good.

The one who practices righteousness is righteous:

(Emphasis) John is contradicting the false teachers who claimed that anyone could become righteous just by accepting their teaching. They claimed that it did not matter if a person continued to live an evil life. It is therefore important in translation to keep the emphasis on the fact that the only people who are righteous in God's sight are those who do right (and no one else). See NEB.

righteous: (Meaning) This means that God accepts him as being good and right, and God approves of what he does.

3:7c

just as Christ is righteous.

- Such people are good in God's sight just like Jesus Christ.
1. It refers to Christ. (BSB, GNT, JBP)
 2. Some think it refers to God. (NEB)

1 John 3:8

Section 2:28–4:6: We should obey God's commands in order to avoid being ashamed when we meet Christ

Read 2:28–4:6 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section (after the main theme in 2:28–29), John is saying that in order not to be ashamed when we meet Christ we must do the following:

3:1–10	We should live pure and righteous lives as Christ did.
3:11–18	We should love and help our fellow Christians.
3:19–24	We should obey God's commands to believe in his Son and to love one another.

4:1–6	We should carefully test what teachers say so that we know whether they are speaking for the Holy Spirit.
-------	---

Paragraph 3:7–10

Read 3:7–10 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: John explains that our behavior shows whether we belong to God or to Satan.

3:8a

The one who practices sin is of the devil,

- But anyone who continually sins clearly belongs to Satan.
- But if a person continues to do what is wrong in God's sight, it is clear that Satan is his father.

The one who practices sin: (Tense) This is the same as "who practices sin" in 3:4. The tense shows that it is referring to continual or habitual sinning. See GNT, JB, LB, JBP.

is of the devil: (Meaning) This means that such a person is under the control of the devil and shares his nature. This is sometimes expressed in translation as "is a child of the devil." (NEB, JBP)

the devil: (Biblical Term) See Evil Spirit in Key Biblical Terms.

3:8b

because the devil has been sinning from the very start.

- This is clear because such a person is just like Satan, who has been sinning since before the beginning of the world.

because: (Logical Relationship) John is saying that we know the devil has always been sinning, and therefore we know that anyone who continually sins must belong to him. He is not saying that if a person keeps sinning this makes him a child of the devil.

from the very start: (Meaning) This is the same Greek phrase as was used in 1:1 and 2:13, which the BSB translates as "from the beginning" in each of those verses. Here, the phrase means the same thing as in each of those verses. It refers to the beginning of the world.

3:8c

This is why the Son of God was revealed, to destroy the works of the devil.

- Jesus Christ, God's Son, came to the world in order to undo everything that Satan has done.

This is why the Son of God was revealed, to destroy the works of the devil: (Parenthesis) This sentence is a comment on the devil's sinful activities which have just been mentioned. It interrupts John's teaching about the two types of people, sinful and righteous, which continues in the next two verses.

was revealed: (Meaning) See the note "Christ appeared" on 3:5a.

destroy the works of the devil: (Meaning) The devil's work is tempting people to sin and getting control over their lives so that they continue to sin. Christ came to free people from the devil's control and to defeat his efforts to tempt people. So the devil's work is in vain.

1 John 3:9

Section 2:28–4:6: We should obey God's commands in order to avoid being ashamed when we meet Christ

Read 2:28–4:6 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section (after the main theme in 2:28–29), John is saying that in order not to be ashamed when we meet Christ we must do the following:

3:1–10	We should live pure and righteous lives as Christ did.
3:11–18	We should love and help our fellow Christians.
3:19–24	We should obey God's commands to believe in his Son and to love one another.
4:1–6	We should carefully test what teachers say so that we know whether they are speaking for the Holy Spirit.

Paragraph 3:7–10

Read 3:7–10 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: John explains that our behavior shows whether we belong to God or to Satan.

3:9a

Anyone born of God refuses to practice sin,

- No person who has become a child of God should continually be sinning,

born of God: (Meaning) As in 2:29b, this means being a child of God. See GNT, NEB, JBP, LB.

practice sin: (Alternative Interpretations) See the note on "keeps on sinning" on 3:6a. The meaning is the same here.

3:9b

because God's seed abides in him;

- because the nature/likeness of God is in his life/soul.

God's seed abides in him: (Alternative Interpretations) There are different interpretations of the topic of this metaphor God's seed and different interpretations of who him refers to:

1. It is generally thought to mean that something of God's nature or God's life is in God's children. (GNT, RSV, JBP)
2. It may mean that God's children remain in God. (RSV footnote)

3:9c

he cannot go on sinning,

- It is impossible for him to be continually sinning
- He cannot be a person who continually does wrong

3:9d

because he has been born of God.

- because he is a child of God.

3:9c–d

he cannot...born of God: (Logical Relationship) The second half of the verse (3:9c–d) is restating the same point as the first half (3:9a–b) in slightly stronger words. The link may need to be made clear in translation. See the Display. See also GNT.

1 John 3:10

Section 2:28–4:6: We should obey God's commands in order to avoid being ashamed when we meet Christ

Read 2:28–4:6 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section (after the main theme in 2:28–29), John is saying that in order not to be ashamed when we meet Christ we must do the following:

3:1–10	We should live pure and righteous lives as Christ did.
3:11–18	We should love and help our fellow Christians.
3:19–24	We should obey God's commands to believe in his Son and to love one another.
4:1–6	We should carefully test what teachers say so that we know whether they are speaking for the Holy Spirit.

Paragraph 3:7–10

Read 3:7–10 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: John explains that our behavior shows whether we belong to God or to Satan.

3:10a

By this the children of God are distinguished from the children of the devil:

- So, what shows us^(incl) clearly who are God's children and who are Satan's children is this,

By this: (Pronoun Reference) The words By this are referring to 3:10b–c.

children of the devil: (Meaning) This means the same as the phrase “is of the devil” in 3:8a.

3:10b

Anyone who does not practice righteousness is not of God,

- that people who do not do what is right in God's sight are not God's children,

3:10c

nor is anyone who does not love his brother.

- and people who do not love other Christians are not God's children.

nor is anyone: (Ellipsis) The full meaning of this is that also the people who do not love their fellow Christians are not the children of God.

1 John 3:11

Section 2:28–4:6: We should obey God's commands in order to avoid being ashamed when we meet Christ

Read 2:28–4:6 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section (after the main theme in 2:28–29), John is saying that in order not to be ashamed when we meet Christ we must do the following:

3:1–10	We should live pure and righteous lives as Christ did.
3:11–18	We should love and help our fellow Christians.
3:19–24	We should obey God's commands to believe in his Son and to love one another.
4:1–6	We should carefully test what teachers say so that we know whether they are speaking for the Holy Spirit.

Paragraph 3:11–12

Read 3:11–12 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: These verses link what John has just said about living pure lives to what he is going to say in 3:13–18 about the importance of loving one another.

3:11a

This is the message you have heard from the beginning:

- ¶ From the time when you^(plur) began to follow Christ you heard God's message

(RSV) For: (Logical Relationship) Although John is moving on to a new topic, Christian love, this verse is closely tied to the last one. In the Greek, verse 11 starts with “Because/For,” as it gives the reason why we know that anyone who does not love his fellow Christians cannot be a child of God. When translating this verse, it will be necessary to consider whether a linking word is needed in order to make this connection to verse 10 clear (as in NEB, RSV, KJV, JBP, LB) or whether the new unit (3:11–12) requires that there be no linking word (as in BSB, NIV, GNT).

the message...beginning: (Meaning) This means that the command to love one another was a main point in the Christian instruction which they received when they first became believers.

3:11b

We should love one another.

- which says that we^(incl) Christians should be loving one another.

1 John 3:12

Section 2:28–4:6: We should obey God's commands in order to avoid being ashamed when we meet Christ

Read 2:28–4:6 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section (after the main theme in 2:28–29), John is saying that in order not to be ashamed when we meet Christ we must do the following:

3:1–10	We should live pure and righteous lives as Christ did.
3:11–18	We should love and help our fellow Christians.
3:19–24	We should obey God's commands to believe in his Son and to love one another.

4:1-6	We should carefully test what teachers say so that we know whether they are speaking for the Holy Spirit.
-------	---

Paragraph 3:11-12

Read 3:11-12 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: These verses link what John has just said about living pure lives to what he is going to say in 3:13-18 about the importance of loving one another.

3:12 (Logical Relationship)

John illustrates the command to love one's brother by using Cain as a contrasting example (from Genesis 4). Cain did not love his brother and his deeds were evil. Read Genesis 4:1-16 before translating this verse.

3:12a**Do not be like Cain,**

- So we^(incl) should not be like that person Cain.

Cain: (New Participant) Cain has not been mentioned previously in this letter, so you may need to be careful how you refer to him in your translation. He was someone who lived a very long time before John and his readers, but they all knew about him.

3:12b**who belonged to the evil one**

- He belonged to Satan, who causes all evil,

belonged to the evil one: (Meaning) See the note on 3:8a "is of the devil." The meaning is the same here.

the evil one: (Meaning) As in 2:13e, this refers to Satan. See the note on 2:13e.

3:12c**and murdered his brother.**

- and so he even killed his younger brother.

brother: (Lexical Problem) This refers to Abel, who was Cain's younger brother.

3:12d**And why did Cain slay him?**

- You see that the reason why Cain killed his brother was exactly this:

And why did Cain slay him?: (Rhetorical Question) This is a rhetorical question used to emphasize the fact that the reason Cain committed murder was because he continually did evil. This showed that he belonged to Satan. If rhetorical questions are not used in this way in your language it will be necessary to use an emphatic statement. See JB.

3:12e**Because his own deeds were evil, while those of his brother were righteous.**

- the things which Cain did were wrong, but his brother was doing what was right in God's sight, and so Cain hated him.

his own deeds: (Meaning) This probably refers to Cain's whole way of life, not just the fact that he made an offering of grain to God instead of an animal sacrifice.

1 John 3:13**Section 2:28-4:6: We should obey God's commands in order to avoid being ashamed when we meet Christ**

Read 2:28-4:6 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section (after the main theme in 2:28-29), John is saying that in order not to be ashamed when we meet Christ we must do the following:

3:1-10	We should live pure and righteous lives as Christ did.
3:11-18	We should love and help our fellow Christians.
3:19-24	We should obey God's commands to believe in his Son and to love one another.
4:1-6	We should carefully test what teachers say so that we know whether they are speaking for the Holy Spirit.

Paragraph 3:13-15

Read 3:13-15 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: John is saying that our love of one another shows that we are different from non-Christians.

3:13 (Logical Relationship)

This verse is giving the lesson to be learned from 3:11-12, namely that the people of the world will always hate God's people, just as Cain hated Abel. In your translation you may need to make this link clear by a linking word (like "So" in GNT), or by a phrase (see the Display).

3:13a**So do not be surprised, brothers,**

- ¶ Therefore, my fellow Christians, you should not be puzzled/amazed

brothers: (Cross-cultural Difference) In all other places in this letter John addresses his readers as “my children,” or “my friends.” He probably calls them his brothers here because he is talking about brotherly love among Christians. In some languages it may sound as if John is referring to two different groups of people, “my children” and “my brothers.” If that is the case in your language you should translate the basic meaning here, “my fellows,” or “my fellow Christians.”

3:13b

if the world hates you.

- that the people of this world hate you just as Cain hated his brother.

if the world hates you: (Lexical Problem) John is certain that the world hates Christians. This is not just a possibility. So it may be better to translate this as “that/when the world hates you.” See JB, RSV.

the world: (Multiple Senses) As in 3:1d, this refers to the people of this world. See the note on 3:1d.

1 John 3:14

Section 2:28–4:6: We should obey God’s commands in order to avoid being ashamed when we meet Christ

Read 2:28–4:6 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section (after the main theme in 2:28–29), John is saying that in order not to be ashamed when we meet Christ we must do the following:

3:1–10	We should live pure and righteous lives as Christ did.
3:11–18	We should love and help our fellow Christians.
3:19–24	We should obey God’s commands to believe in his Son and to love one another.
4:1–6	We should carefully test what teachers say so that we know whether they are speaking for the Holy Spirit.

Paragraph 3:13–15

Read 3:13–15 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: John is saying that our love of one another shows that we are different from non-Christians.

3:14a

We know that we have passed from death to life,

- As for us^(incl) we know that we have become free from the power of death and we now have eternal life.
- We know that truly we are no longer like dead people, we have become people who have real life.

We: (Emphasis) The emphasis here is on the difference between Christians and the people of the world. This difference is seen in the way Christians love other Christians, which proves that they have passed from death to eternal life. In the Greek the pronoun “We” is emphatic to make the contrast clear. See NEB.

we have passed from death to life: (Metaphor) The topic of this extended metaphor is that as Christians we are no longer under the power of death and Satan, but we now have eternal life from God. Thus we are like people who were dead but have now come to life.

3:14b

because we love our brothers.

- We^(incl) know this because we are now loving our fellow Christians.

because we love our brothers: (Logical Relationship) This is not giving the reason why we have passed from death to life. It is giving the reason why we know that we have passed from death to life. To avoid confusion about this many translations repeat here the phrase “We know this because.” See GNT, JB, NEB. Others such as LB change the order of clauses within the sentence.

3:14c

The one who does not love remains in death.

- Any person who does not love other Christians is clearly still under the power of death.
- If someone does not love other Christians he is still like a dead person.

who does not love: (Lexical Problem) No object of the verb love is mentioned in this clause, but John is clearly still referring to loving other Christians. This can be made explicit if in your language the verb requires an object.

1 John 3:15

Section 2:28–4:6: We should obey God’s commands in order to avoid being ashamed when we meet Christ

Read 2:28–4:6 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section (after the main theme in 2:28–29), John is saying that in order not to be ashamed when we meet Christ we must do the following:

3:1-10	We should live pure and righteous lives as Christ did.
3:11-18	We should love and help our fellow Christians.
3:19-24	We should obey God's commands to believe in his Son and to love one another.
4:1-6	We should carefully test what teachers say so that we know whether they are speaking for the Holy Spirit.

Paragraph 3:13-15

Read 3:13-15 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: John is saying that our love of one another shows that we are different from non-Christians.

3:15a

Everyone who hates his brother is a murderer,

- In God's sight anyone who hates other people is just the same as a murderer.

his brother: (Multiple Senses) This is used here in a slightly different sense to the way it was used in 3:14b. Here in 3:15a it means "his fellows" or "other people."

is a murderer: (Meaning) John is teaching his readers that God considers hatred to be the same as murder.

3:15b

and you know that eternal life does not reside in a murderer.

- And it is clear that a person who murders people is not living God's eternal life.

you know that: (Focus) The main point of 3:15b is that murderers do not have eternal life. The phrase you know that merely gives emphasis to this, so it may be translated as a parenthesis, or by some word which marks emphasis. See JB, NEB.

eternal life does not reside: (Meaning) John is not saying that a murderer cannot have eternal life. Rather he is saying that a person who murders is clearly not living the sort of life which God gives us, which we call "eternal."

1 John 3:16

Section 2:28-4:6: We should obey God's commands in order to avoid being ashamed when we meet Christ

Read 2:28-4:6 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section (after the main theme in 2:28-29), John is saying that in order not to be

ashamed when we meet Christ we must do the following:

3:1-10	We should live pure and righteous lives as Christ did.
3:11-18	We should love and help our fellow Christians.
3:19-24	We should obey God's commands to believe in his Son and to love one another.
4:1-6	We should carefully test what teachers say so that we know whether they are speaking for the Holy Spirit.

Paragraph 3:16-18

Read 3:16-18 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: John here emphasizes the theme of love, which he introduced in 3:11. He is showing that love involves helping each other.

3:16a

By this we know what love is: Jesus laid down His life for us,

- ¶ When Jesus willingly died for our^(incl) sakes he showed us clearly how we should truly love people.

By this: (Pronoun Reference) The words By this refer to the words Jesus laid down His life for us in the second part of this sentence. John is saying that Jesus has showed us that loving someone means we should be willing to do anything for them; we should even be willing to die for them.

love: (Emphasis) It may be necessary to give emphasis to love here in order to show that in this and the next two verses, John is demonstrating what love really involves.

laid down His life: (Metaphor) The topic of this metaphor is that Christ was willing to treat life like a piece of clothing which a person might take off and lay aside. If there is no suitable metaphor to replace this in your language, you can just say that Christ willingly died for us.

3:16b

and we ought to lay down our lives for our brothers.

- And we also ought to be willing even to die for the sake of our fellow Christians.

and we: (Alternative Interpretations) There are different interpretations of the relationship between this sentence and the previous one:

1. John is probably saying that our duty to be willing to even die for our brothers is a second reason for

his teaching in 3:18 that we should be loving our brothers in practical ways even now.

2. GNT and LB translate 3:16b as a conclusion drawn from the fact that Jesus was willing to die for us.

we ought to lay down our lives: (Meaning) John is not saying that we should go and seek ways of being killed. He is reminding us that if we are ever able to save our brothers' lives by our own death then we should not refuse to die.

1 John 3:17

Section 2:28–4:6: We should obey God's commands in order to avoid being ashamed when we meet Christ

Read 2:28–4:6 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section (after the main theme in 2:28–29), John is saying that in order not to be ashamed when we meet Christ we must do the following:

3:1–10	We should live pure and righteous lives as Christ did.
3:11–18	We should love and help our fellow Christians.
3:19–24	We should obey God's commands to believe in his Son and to love one another.
4:1–6	We should carefully test what teachers say so that we know whether they are speaking for the Holy Spirit.

Paragraph 3:16–18

Read 3:16–18 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: John here emphasizes the theme of love, which he introduced in 3:11. He is showing that love involves helping each other.

3:17a

If anyone with earthly possessions

- But if someone has what as he needs to live on

If anyone: (Parenthesis) John interrupts his argument to give, as a warning, an example of a Christian who does not truly love his fellow Christian.

with earthly possessions: (Meaning) This refers to food, clothes, housing and the means of earning a living. It means having enough to live with (see NEB, LB). It does not mean that he is rich.

3:17b

sees his brother in need,

- and he knows that a certain fellow Christian does not have enough to live on,

3:17c

but withholds his compassion from him,

- and if he still refuses to help that person,

but withholds his compassion from him: (Meaning)

This refers to both the person's attitude and his actions. His brother's problems do not interest or affect him and he does nothing to help his brother.

3:17d

how can the love of God abide in him?

- he cannot claim that God is causing him to love people.

how can the love of God abide in him?: (Rhetorical Question) The rhetorical question is used here in order to emphasize the fact that it is in no way possible for such a person to have the love of God, even if he claims to have it.

the love of God: (Alternative Interpretations) There is a lot of disagreement about the meaning of this phrase:

1. The sentence probably means, "He cannot claim that God is causing him to love people," (NEB, RSV, LB) since John's theme here is the love we show to people.
2. Others think it means, "He cannot claim that he loves God." (GNT)
3. Others think it means, "He cannot claim that he loves people in the same way that God loves people."

1 John 3:18

Section 2:28–4:6: We should obey God's commands in order to avoid being ashamed when we meet Christ

Read 2:28–4:6 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section (after the main theme in 2:28–29), John is saying that in order not to be ashamed when we meet Christ we must do the following:

3:1–10	We should live pure and righteous lives as Christ did.
3:11–18	We should love and help our fellow Christians.
3:19–24	We should obey God's commands to believe in his Son and to love one another.

4:1-6	We should carefully test what teachers say so that we know whether they are speaking for the Holy Spirit.
-------	---

Paragraph 3:16-18

Read 3:16-18 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: John here emphasizes the theme of love, which he introduced in 3:11. He is showing that love involves helping each other.

3:18 (Logical Relationship)

Since this verse gives the main point of John's argument, based on 3:16-17, it may be necessary in translation to make this clear. See the Display.

3:18a

Little children, let us love not in word and speech,

- My children, since these things are so, we^(incl) should not just say that we love each other.

let us love not in: (Meaning) In translation it is important to avoid implying here that we should never say we love someone. John certainly assumes that we say we love people, but he is here warning that we should not only say we love people, we should also do things to help them.

love: (Lexical Problem) John is referring to loving our brothers or each other, and this can be made explicit in translation if it is necessary for the verb love to have an object.

speech: (Metaphor) The Greek word that the BSB translates as speech is more literally "tongue." This is a metaphorical way of referring to speech.

3:18b

but in action and truth.

- We should really help each other, just as God truly loves us.

and truth: (Meaning) If we actually help one another our love will be true love in accordance with God's truth.

1 John 3:19

Section 2:28-4:6: We should obey God's commands in order to avoid being ashamed when we meet Christ

Read 2:28-4:6 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section (after the main theme in 2:28-29), John is saying that in order not to be ashamed when we meet Christ we must do the following:

3:1-10	We should live pure and righteous lives as Christ did.
3:11-18	We should love and help our fellow Christians.
3:19-24	We should obey God's commands to believe in his Son and to love one another.
4:1-6	We should carefully test what teachers say so that we know whether they are speaking for the Holy Spirit.

Paragraph 3:19-20

Read 3:19-20 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: If we love one another we will not be ashamed before God when we are praying to him.

3:19a

And by this we will know

- ¶ If we^(incl) truly love each other like that, we will know for sure

this: (Pronoun Reference) The word this refers back to what John has said in the previous verse about loving each other truly. To make this clear in translation it may be necessary to restate it here. See the Display.

we will know: (Tense) As the BSB indicates in English, the tense in the Greek is future, probably because John is saying that we will know that we belong to the truth if we put 3:18 into practice.

3:19b

that we belong to the truth,

- that we belong to God, who shows people what is right and true.

we belong to the truth: (Meaning) The basic meaning of truth in John's writings is "everything which is in accordance with God's character." This is because God is the real standard of what is true and right. So when John says we belong to the truth, he means that we belong to God and we are living according to his will.

3:19c

and will assure our hearts in His presence:

- And if we truly love each other we will not be worried/anxious when we pray to God,
- And it causes our thoughts/consciences to be at peace when we think about God,

in His presence: (Meaning) John is referring to when we are praying or when we think about God and remember that we are in his presence.

1 John 3:20

Section 2:28–4:6: We should obey God’s commands in order to avoid being ashamed when we meet Christ

Read 2:28–4:6 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section (after the main theme in 2:28–29), John is saying that in order not to be ashamed when we meet Christ we must do the following:

3:1–10	We should live pure and righteous lives as Christ did.
3:11–18	We should love and help our fellow Christians.
3:19–24	We should obey God’s commands to believe in his Son and to love one another.
4:1–6	We should carefully test what teachers say so that we know whether they are speaking for the Holy Spirit.

Paragraph 3:19–20

Read 3:19–20 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: If we love one another we will not be ashamed before God when we are praying to him.

3:20a

Even if our hearts condemn us,

- even if our thoughts/consciences tell us that we are sinners.

our hearts condemn us: (Meaning) John is talking about how in such circumstances we are especially aware of our sins and our unworthiness before God. He is not referring to times when the Holy Spirit reminds us about specific sins which we need to repent of.

3:20b

God is greater than our hearts,

- We will be at peace because we understand that God knows very much more than we know in our thoughts/consciences,

greater than: (Lexical Problem) The Greek word does not specify in what sense God is greater than us or our hearts, but the end of this verse makes it clear that John is talking about God’s greater knowledge.

than our hearts: (Metaphor) This is referring to our thoughts, so the basic meaning here is “God knows much more than we know.”

3:20c

and He knows all things.

- and so he knows everything that we do.

He knows all things: (Meaning) This specifically refers to God knowing all that we do.

1 John 3:21

Section 2:28–4:6: We should obey God’s commands in order to avoid being ashamed when we meet Christ

Read 2:28–4:6 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section (after the main theme in 2:28–29), John is saying that in order not to be ashamed when we meet Christ we must do the following:

3:1–10	We should live pure and righteous lives as Christ did.
3:11–18	We should love and help our fellow Christians.
3:19–24	We should obey God’s commands to believe in his Son and to love one another.
4:1–6	We should carefully test what teachers say so that we know whether they are speaking for the Holy Spirit.

Paragraph 3:21–24

Read 3:21–24 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: Here John repeats the main theme of this section, saying that we must obey God’s commands to believe in Jesus and love each other.

3:21 (Alternative Interpretations)

There are two interpretations of how this verse is related to 3:19–20:

1. This verse is probably describing the situation when our hearts do not condemn us, in contrast with the situation mentioned in 3:20. In this case the verses may be linked with a word like “But” (see LB), or have no linking word.
2. Some think this verse is referring to the situation which results when we have “assured our hearts” (see 3:19). In that case the verses would be linked with “And so” (see GNT).

3:21a

Beloved, if our hearts do not condemn us,

- ¶ My dear people, when we know in our thoughts/consciences that we are not sinners

our hearts do not condemn us: (Meaning) See the note on 3:20.

3:21b**we have confidence before God,**

- we are not afraid when we pray to God.

we have confidence before God: (Meaning) This particularly refers to not being afraid of speaking freely to God.

1 John 3:22**Section 2:28–4:6: We should obey God’s commands in order to avoid being ashamed when we meet Christ**

Read 2:28–4:6 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section (after the main theme in 2:28–29), John is saying that in order not to be ashamed when we meet Christ we must do the following:

3:1–10	We should live pure and righteous lives as Christ did.
3:11–18	We should love and help our fellow Christians.
3:19–24	We should obey God’s commands to believe in his Son and to love one another.
4:1–6	We should carefully test what teachers say so that we know whether they are speaking for the Holy Spirit.

Paragraph 3:21–24

Read 3:21–24 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: Here John repeats the main theme of this section, saying that we must obey God’s commands to believe in Jesus and love each other.

3:22a**and we will receive from Him whatever we ask,**

- And since we are not sinners God will give us everything we ask him for,

and we will receive: (Logical Relationship) This is a second, and more important, consequence of the fact that God does not condemn us as sinners when we pray to him.

3:22b**because we keep His commandments**

- because we are doing what he told us to do

3:22c**and do what is pleasing in His sight.**

- and we are living in a way which pleases him.

1 John 3:23**Section 2:28–4:6: We should obey God’s commands in order to avoid being ashamed when we meet Christ**

Read 2:28–4:6 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section (after the main theme in 2:28–29), John is saying that in order not to be ashamed when we meet Christ we must do the following:

3:1–10	We should live pure and righteous lives as Christ did.
3:11–18	We should love and help our fellow Christians.
3:19–24	We should obey God’s commands to believe in his Son and to love one another.
4:1–6	We should carefully test what teachers say so that we know whether they are speaking for the Holy Spirit.

Paragraph 3:21–24

Read 3:21–24 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: Here John repeats the main theme of this section, saying that we must obey God’s commands to believe in Jesus and love each other.

3:23a**And this is His commandment:**

- The main things which God has told us^(incl) to do are

this: (Pronoun Reference) The word this refers to 3:23b–d, believing in Jesus and loving one another.

His commandment: (Lexical Problem) John here says commandment in the singular to show that belief and love are the summary or main point of all God’s commands. In some languages it may not be possible to have the singular this and commandment referring to the two verbs “believe” and “love.” If that is the case in your language, you can say something like “These are the most important things he told us to do.”

3:23b**that we should believe in the name of His Son, Jesus Christ,**

- that we should believe that Jesus Christ is his Son,

that we should believe in: (Biblical Term) See believe in Key Biblical Terms.

the name: (Figure of Speech) This refers to Jesus’ authority and character and everything about him as God’s Son.

3:23c and we should love one another

- and that we should be loving one another

3:23d just as He commanded us.

- just as Jesus told us to do.

as He commanded: (Alternative Interpretations) It is not completely clear who He refers to here:

1. It probably means “Christ” (see GNT), since it was Christ who gave the commandment to love. See John 13:34.
2. It may mean “God.”

1 John 3:24

Section 2:28–4:6: We should obey God’s commands in order to avoid being ashamed when we meet Christ

Read 2:28–4:6 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section (after the main theme in 2:28–29), John is saying that in order not to be ashamed when we meet Christ we must do the following:

3:1–10	We should live pure and righteous lives as Christ did.
3:11–18	We should love and help our fellow Christians.
3:19–24	We should obey God’s commands to believe in his Son and to love one another.
4:1–6	We should carefully test what teachers say so that we know whether they are speaking for the Holy Spirit.

Paragraph 3:21–24

Read 3:21–24 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: Here John repeats the main theme of this section, saying that we must obey God’s commands to believe in Jesus and love each other.

3:24a Whoever keeps His commandments remains in God,

- Anyone who does what God said people should do is united with God,

Whoever: (Meaning) This means “anyone/everyone who.” It includes John and his readers.

His commandments: (Pronoun Reference) This refers to God’s commands. But since the last person men-

tioned in the previous sentence was Christ, it may be necessary to make “God” explicit here. See GNT, JB, JBP, LB.

in God: (Collocation) As in 2:5, this refers to being in union with God. See the note on 2:5.

3:24b and God in him.

- and God is united with him.

and God in him: (Ellipsis) The full meaning here is that God lives in them, just as they live in God. In your language it may not be natural to use the same expression for both of these, so you may need to say something like “they are constantly united with God and God is in their hearts.”

3:24c And by this we know that He remains in us:

- What shows us^(incl) plainly that God is always united with us

And by this: (Pronoun Reference) This phrase refers forward to 3:24d.

**3:24c-d
we know...by the Spirit:** (Meaning) John means that the presence of the Holy Spirit in us proves that God is living in us.

3:24d by the Spirit He has given us.

- is the Holy Spirit, who God has caused to live in us.

the Spirit: (Biblical Term) This means the Holy Spirit. See Spirit in Key Biblical Terms.

1 John 4:1

Section 2:28–4:6: We should obey God’s commands in order to avoid being ashamed when we meet Christ

Read 2:28–4:6 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section (after the main theme in 2:28–29), John is saying that in order not to be ashamed when we meet Christ we must do the following:

3:1–10	We should live pure and righteous lives as Christ did.
3:11–18	We should love and help our fellow Christians.
3:19–24	We should obey God’s commands to believe in his Son and to love one another.

4:1-6	We should carefully test what teachers say so that we know whether they are speaking for the Holy Spirit.
-------	---

Paragraph 4:1-3

Read 4:1-3 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: John warns his readers to test anyone who claims to have a message from the Holy Spirit.

4:1a**Beloved, do not believe every spirit,**

- ¶ My dear people, do not believe the words of anyone who just says that he has the Holy Spirit of God in him.
- ¶ You who I love, do not trust a person just because he claims to be teaching something he has received from the Holy Spirit.

every spirit: (Meaning) See Spirit in Key Biblical Terms. Here John is telling his readers not to accept without question the words of anyone who claims that they received from the Holy Spirit the message which they are proclaiming or teaching. John warns that some people who do this are false prophets and their messages come from evil spirits, which are enemies of Christ. Therefore the term spirit here includes both the Holy Spirit and evil spirits. In translation it may be clearer if it is made explicit that every spirit refers to people who claim to be speaking messages from God. See GNT, LB.

4:1b**but test the spirits**

- Instead, you^(plur) should examine carefully what such a person says,

test the spirits: (Meaning) This again refers to testing the words of people who give messages or teaching in God's name. In translation it must not sound like an instruction to Christians to seek oracles or soothsayers or spirit diviners.

4:1c**to see whether they are from God.**

- so that you will know if he really does have the Spirit of God in him.
- to find out whether his teaching was truly given to him by the Holy Spirit.

from God: (Meaning) If the spirit is from God, it is the Holy Spirit, since no other "spirit" comes from God.

4:1d**For many false prophets have gone out into the world.**

- You need to do this because everywhere there are many liars who claim falsely to be giving messages which they have received from God.

For many: (Logical Relationship) This clause gives John's reason for his instruction to test those who claim to speak for God. In your language, it may be more natural to put the reason first. For example:

"Everywhere there are many liars who claim that they are speaking words from God. So do not believe everyone who says that he has the Spirit of God in him. Instead you should test everything so that you may know whether that person really has God's Spirit."

false prophets: (Biblical Term) See prophet in Key Biblical Terms.

have gone out: (Multiple Senses) This is not used here in the sense of leaving a specific place; rather it is referring to many people going to different places.

into the world: (Multiple Senses) See world in Key Biblical Terms. Here world is used in the sense of "everywhere."

1 John 4:2**Section 2:28-4:6: We should obey God's commands in order to avoid being ashamed when we meet Christ**

Read 2:28-4:6 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section (after the main theme in 2:28-29), John is saying that in order not to be ashamed when we meet Christ we must do the following:

3:1-10	We should live pure and righteous lives as Christ did.
3:11-18	We should love and help our fellow Christians.
3:19-24	We should obey God's commands to believe in his Son and to love one another.
4:1-6	We should carefully test what teachers say so that we know whether they are speaking for the Holy Spirit.

Paragraph 4:1-3

Read 4:1-3 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: John warns his readers to test anyone who claims to have a message from the Holy Spirit.

4:2a

By this you will know the Spirit of God:

- The test/way by which you will know that a person has the Spirit of God is this,
- If you want to find out if a certain person has truly received his teaching from the Holy Spirit, consider this,

this: (Pronoun Reference) The pronoun this points forward, referring to the rest of this verse and the next verse. John is showing how we can test what these people say.

the Spirit of God: (Biblical Term) This is another name for the Holy Spirit.

4:2b

Every spirit that confesses that Jesus Christ has come in the flesh is from God,

- that anyone who says that Jesus Christ came to this world as a human being, it is the Holy Spirit of God which he has in him.
- that if someone says that Jesus Christ was born as a human being, he is giving teaching which he has received from the Holy Spirit.

Every spirit: (Meaning) See the note on 4:1a.

Jesus Christ: (Alternative Interpretations) There is disagreement about whether Christ is part of the name or whether it is here the title meaning “Messiah”:

1. Probably Christ is part of the name. (BSB, GNT, NIV, NEB, RSV, KJV, JBP)
2. Some think that Christ is the title, and that the sentence therefore means, “Jesus is the Messiah and he came as a human being.” (JB)

has come: (Meaning) This refers to when Jesus came into the world.

in the flesh: (Biblical Term) See flesh in Key Biblical Terms. The phrase in the flesh is used here with the meaning “as a human being.” See GNT, JBP, LB.

1 John 4:3

Section 2:28–4:6: We should obey God’s commands in order to avoid being ashamed when we meet Christ

Read 2:28–4:6 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section (after the main theme in 2:28–29), John is saying that in order not to be

ashamed when we meet Christ we must do the following:

3:1–10	We should live pure and righteous lives as Christ did.
3:11–18	We should love and help our fellow Christians.
3:19–24	We should obey God’s commands to believe in his Son and to love one another.
4:1–6	We should carefully test what teachers say so that we know whether they are speaking for the Holy Spirit.

Paragraph 4:1–3

Read 4:1–3 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: John warns his readers to test anyone who claims to have a message from the Holy Spirit.

4:3a

and every spirit that does not confess Jesus is not from God.

- But anyone who says that Jesus did not come to this world as a human being does not have the Holy Spirit of God in him.
- And if someone says that Jesus was not born as a human being, you can be sure that he did not receive his teaching from the Holy Spirit.

does not confess Jesus: (Ellipsis) The full meaning here is “does not acknowledge that Jesus Christ has come as a human being.”

4:3b

This is the spirit of the antichrist,

- That person has the spirit/power of the well-known enemy of Christ in him causing him to say those things.

the spirit of the antichrist: (Meaning) John means that such a person is preaching and teaching by the power of the antichrist or by an evil spirit sent by the antichrist.

the antichrist: (Biblical Term) See antichrist in Key Biblical Terms.

4:3c

which you have heard is coming

- You have heard that that spirit/power will come to this world,

which: (Pronoun Reference) The word which refers to the spirit of the antichrist, not to the antichrist himself.

4:3d
and which is already in the world at this time.

- and so it has come, and it is in this world even now.

1 John 4:4

Section 2:28–4:6: We should obey God’s commands in order to avoid being ashamed when we meet Christ

Read 2:28–4:6 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section (after the main theme in 2:28–29), John is saying that in order not to be ashamed when we meet Christ we must do the following:

3:1–10	We should live pure and righteous lives as Christ did.
3:11–18	We should love and help our fellow Christians.
3:19–24	We should obey God’s commands to believe in his Son and to love one another.
4:1–6	We should carefully test what teachers say so that we know whether they are speaking for the Holy Spirit.

Paragraph 4:4–6

Read 4:4–6 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: Since John has just given his readers a warning, he now reassures them that they have the Holy Spirit in them, and so they will know who is truly speaking messages from the Holy Spirit.

4:4a
You, little children, are from God

- ¶ But you, my children, are God’s people,

from God: (Meaning) The Greek phrase used here is the same as that used in 3:10a and other places meaning “children/people of God.”

4:4b
and have overcome them,

- and you have rejected all the false teachings of these people.

have overcome them: (Metaphor) This does not refer to a physical conflict. John is talking about how the Christians were not persuaded when these other people tried to convince them to accept their false

teaching. They had been able to answer all the arguments of the false prophets.

them: (Pronoun Reference) This refers to the false prophets. It is clear from the whole book that they are the same people as the “enemies of Christ” (GNT) mentioned in 2:18–19. As the last reference to them was in 4:1, many translations refer to them here with a noun phrase meaning “false prophets.”

4:4c
because greater is He who is in you than he who is in the world.

- You^(plur) have been able to do this because the power of the Holy Spirit, who is in you, is greater than the power of Satan, who rules the people of this world who do not know God

greater is: (Lexical Problem) It is clear from the rest of this verse that this means greater in respect to power and authority. See GNT, JBP, LB.

He who is in you: (Alternative Interpretations) There are two interpretations of who this refers to:

1. It probably means the Holy Spirit (see GNT), since the Holy Spirit is in focus in this passage.
2. Some think it means Christ, or God.

he who is in the world: (Alternative Interpretations) There are two interpretations of who this refers to:

1. It probably refers to the spirit and power of the antichrist as mentioned in 4:3 (GNT). See the note on 4:3b.
2. Some think it refers to Satan, or to the antichrist himself (JBP).

the world: (Multiple Senses) This is used here in the sense of “the people of the world who do not know God.”

1 John 4:5

Section 2:28–4:6: We should obey God’s commands in order to avoid being ashamed when we meet Christ

Read 2:28–4:6 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section (after the main theme in 2:28–29), John is saying that in order not to be ashamed when we meet Christ we must do the following:

3:1–10	We should live pure and righteous lives as Christ did.
3:11–18	We should love and help our fellow Christians.

3:19-24	We should obey God's commands to believe in his Son and to love one another.
4:1-6	We should carefully test what teachers say so that we know whether they are speaking for the Holy Spirit.

Paragraph 4:4-6

Read 4:4-6 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: Since John has just given his readers a warning, he now reassures them that they have the Holy Spirit in them, and so they will know who is truly speaking messages from the Holy Spirit.

4:5a**They are of the world.**

- Those people who falsely claim to be giving God's teaching are just people of this world.
- Those liars are people who do not know God.

They: (Pronoun Reference) It needs to be clear in translation that this refers to the false prophets.

of the world: (Meaning) The false prophets are not children of God; they belong to the evil world of everything that is opposed to God. See world, age (section 4) in Key Biblical Terms.

4:5b**That is why they speak from the world's perspective,**

- So their teaching is just the teaching of people of this world,
- So what they say is just like what people who do not know God say,

speak from the world's perspective: (Meaning) John means that the teaching of these people is based on human wisdom, not on God's revelation.

4:5c**and the world listens to them.**

- and therefore the people of this world accept their teaching.
- and so the people who do not know God believe what they say.

and the world listens to them: (Logical Relationship) This is a second result of the fact that the false prophets are "from the world." (The first result is in 4:5b.)

the world: (Multiple Senses) Here world has a slightly different sense from that which it has in the beginning of this sentence. Here it means the same as in 4:4d, "the people of the world who do not know God."

1 John 4:6**Section 2:28-4:6: We should obey God's commands in order to avoid being ashamed when we meet Christ**

Read 2:28-4:6 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section (after the main theme in 2:28-29), John is saying that in order not to be ashamed when we meet Christ we must do the following:

3:1-10	We should live pure and righteous lives as Christ did.
3:11-18	We should love and help our fellow Christians.
3:19-24	We should obey God's commands to believe in his Son and to love one another.
4:1-6	We should carefully test what teachers say so that we know whether they are speaking for the Holy Spirit.

Paragraph 4:4-6

Read 4:4-6 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: Since John has just given his readers a warning, he now reassures them that they have the Holy Spirit in them, and so they will know who is truly speaking messages from the Holy Spirit.

4:6a**We are from God.**

- As for us^(excl) apostles, we are God's people,

We: (Alternative Interpretations) There are two interpretations of this pronoun:

1. It is probably exclusive, meaning "we apostles," since the believers had heard the teaching of the apostles from John.
2. Some think it is inclusive, meaning "we apostles together with you believers."

4:6b**Whoever knows God listens to us;**

- so everyone who knows God accepts our^(excl) teaching.

4:6c**whoever is not from God does not listen to us.**

- But anyone who is not one of God's people will not accept our^(excl) teaching.

4:6d**That is how we know the Spirit of truth**

- So this matter of whose teaching a person accepts is what shows us^(incl) whether that person has in him the Spirit of God, who reveals the truth,
- That is how we^(incl) are able to know whether a person received the teaching he is giving from the Holy Spirit, who is true,

That: (Pronoun Reference) The word That refers to what John has just said. He is telling his readers that to test whether a person's teaching comes from the Holy Spirit or from an evil spirit, they should see if that person follows the apostles' teaching or not.

Spirit of truth: ("Of" Construction) This means the Holy Spirit, who reveals the truth about God.

4:6e and the spirit of deception.

- or whether he has in him the power/spirit of Satan, which deceives people.
- or whether he received his teaching from Satan, who tells lies.

spirit of deception: ("Of" Construction) This means an evil spirit, or the spirit of the antichrist, which deceives people.

1 John 4:7

Section 4:7–5:12: We should love one another because of what God has done for us

Read 4:7–5:12 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John gives two reasons why we should love one another:

4:7-12	God has shown us what true love is by sending his Son to die for us.
4:13-21	God has loved us so much that we have a duty to love others.

At the end of the section, in **5:1–12**, he shows how it is believing in Jesus that enables us to both love and obey God.

Paragraph 4:7–10

Read 4:7–10 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: In these verses John urges us to love one another because God showed us how much he loved us by sending his Son to die for us.

4:7a

Beloved, let us love one another,

- ¶ My dear people, we^(incl) should all keep on loving each other.

let us love: (Tense) The tense of the Greek verb here shows that this is an order or encouragement to continue loving each other.

4:7b

because love comes from God.

- I say this because it is God who makes us^(incl) able to love others.

love comes from: (Metaphor) See the note on 2:16e "is not from." The basic meaning of the metaphor here is that love is something especially associated with God and that he is the one who causes and enables Christians to love others.

4:7c

Everyone who loves has been born of God and knows God.

- So when anyone of you loves other people, it is clear that he is a child of God and that he knows God.

Everyone who loves: (Meaning) John is referring to Christians who love others. He does not mean that any non-Christian who loves someone is a child of God. In translation this may need to be made clear by saying, "Anyone of you who loves."

who loves: (Lexical Problem) No object of love is mentioned here, but throughout this section John is talking about loving other people. So if the verb "love" requires an object in your language, you can say "who loves other people." This applies also to 4:8a.

born of God: (Metaphor) This refers to the same idea as being a child of God, because such a person has received spiritual life from God.

1 John 4:8

Section 4:7–5:12: We should love one another because of what God has done for us

Read 4:7–5:12 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John gives two reasons why we should love one another:

4:7-12	God has shown us what true love is by sending his Son to die for us.
4:13-21	God has loved us so much that we have a duty to love others.

At the end of the section, in **5:1–12**, he shows how it is believing in Jesus that enables us to both love and obey God.

Paragraph 4:7–10

Read 4:7–10 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: In these verses John urges us to love one another because God showed us how much he loved us by sending his Son to die for us.

4:8a

Whoever does not love does not know God,

- Anyone who does not love others does not know God at all.

4:8b

because God is love.

- We^(incl) know this because in everything he does God is always loving people.

because: (Logical Relationship) This clause (God is love) gives the reason why we know that such a person does not know God. The most important thing about God is his love, so anyone who knows him will certainly show some of his love to others.

God is love: (Meaning) This does not mean that God is the same thing as love, or that God is nothing more than love. John is saying that all of God's character is summed up by the word "love," and that the most important thing about him is his love, and everything he does is done out of love for people.

1 John 4:9

Section 4:7–5:12: We should love one another because of what God has done for us

Read 4:7–5:12 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John gives two reasons why we should love one another:

4:7–12	God has shown us what true love is by sending his Son to die for us.
4:13–21	God has loved us so much that we have a duty to love others.

At the end of the section, in **5:1–12**, he shows how it is believing in Jesus that enables us to both love and obey God.

Paragraph 4:7–10

Read 4:7–10 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: In these verses John urges us to love one another because God showed us how much he loved us by sending his Son to die for us.

4:9a

This is how God's love was revealed among us:

- The way by which God has clearly shown us^(incl) that he loves people is this:

This: (Pronoun Reference) The word This refers forward to 4:9b, God's sending his Son into the world.

among us: (Alternative Interpretations) There are two interpretations of the meaning of the Greek phrase used here:

1. It probably indicates to whom God revealed his love, so the clause means, "God revealed/demonstrated to us his love (for people)." (BSB, NIV, NEB, RSV)
2. Some think it indicates who God loves. So the clause would then mean, "God showed that he loves us." (GNT, JB, KJV, LB)

4:9b

God sent His one and only Son into the world,

- he caused his only Son to come to this world

one and only: (Alternative Interpretations) There are two opinions about the meaning of the Greek word used here:

1. Almost certainly it means "unique, the only one who exists." (BSB, NIV, GNT, JB, NEB, RSV, JBP, LB)
2. A few people think it means "the only one who was born." (NIV margin, KJV)

4:9c

so that we might live through Him.

- so that we should have true life because of him.
- so his Son might cause us to really live.

we might live through Him: (Meaning) John means that Christ has caused us to be truly alive, he has given us eternal life.

1 John 4:10

Section 4:7–5:12: We should love one another because of what God has done for us

Read 4:7–5:12 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John gives two reasons why we should love one another:

4:7–12	God has shown us what true love is by sending his Son to die for us.
4:13–21	God has loved us so much that we have a duty to love others.

At the end of the section, in **5:1–12**, he shows how it is believing in Jesus that enables us to both love and obey God.

Paragraph 4:7–10

Read 4:7–10 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: In these verses John urges us to love one another because God showed us how much he loved us by sending his Son to die for us.

4:10a

And love consists in this: not that we loved God,

- The true way to love people is not the way that we^(incl) have loved God,
- Real love is not what we^(incl) do when we love God,

And love consists in this: (Lexical Problem) In some languages it may not be possible to talk about love without indicating the object of the love. If that is the case in your language you may have to refer to “the right/true way for someone to love others.”

this: (Pronoun Reference) The word this points forward to 4:10b–c where John says that real love is what God showed by sending his Son to this world. However John first states that real love is not what we show by loving God. It may therefore be clearer to restructure the sentence as:

Real love is not what we show by loving God,
rather it is what God showed by loving us...

4:10b

but that He loved us

- rather it is the way that God loved us.

4:10c

and sent His Son as the atoning sacrifice for our sins.

- God loved us by sending his Son to take the punishment for our wrong deeds by his death on the cross

and sent: (Logical Relationship) God’s love and his sending his Son are not two independent facts. Sending his Son was the means by which he put his love into action. This relationship may need to be made explicit in your translation. See the Display.

the atoning sacrifice: (Meaning) This is what was referred to in 2:2a. (See the note on that verse.) Here the main point in focus is that by sending Jesus to die, God provided the way for our sins to be forgiven. See GNT.

1 John 4:11

Section 4:7–5:12: We should love one another because of what God has done for us

Read 4:7–5:12 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John gives two reasons why we should love one another:

4:7–12	God has shown us what true love is by sending his Son to die for us.
4:13–21	God has loved us so much that we have a duty to love others.

At the end of the section, in **5:1–12**, he shows how it is believing in Jesus that enables us to both love and obey God.

Paragraph 4:11–12

Read 4:11–12 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: Here John appeals to us to love one another so that God can truly live in us and cause his love to reach others through us.

4:11a

Beloved, if God so loved us,

- ¶ My dear people, since God has loved us^(incl) very much in that way,

if: (Multiple Senses) The conjunction if is not used here to introduce something that might or might not be true. Here it refers to something that is known to be true, so in many languages a conjunction like “since” or “because” will be more appropriate. See NIV and Display.

so loved us: (Multiple Senses) Here the word so is used in the sense of “so much.” It means that God loved us very much and as a result of that he sent his Son to die for us.

4:11b

we also ought to love one another.

- it is right that we for our part should all love one another.

1 John 4:12

Section 4:7–5:12: We should love one another because of what God has done for us

Read 4:7–5:12 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John gives two reasons why we should love one another:

4:7–12	God has shown us what true love is by sending his Son to die for us.
4:13–21	God has loved us so much that we have a duty to love others.

At the end of the section, in **5:1–12**, he shows how it is believing in Jesus that enables us to both love and obey God.

Paragraph 4:11–12

Read 4:11–12 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: Here John appeals to us to love one another so that God can truly live in us and cause his love to reach others through us.

4:12 (Focus)

The focus of this verse is on two things that will happen if we love one another: (a) God will live in us, and (b) his love will become perfect in us. The statement that no one has ever seen God is not in focus, it is just emphasizing how amazing it is that God lives in us. The verse could therefore be restructured as:

If we love one another, then even though nobody has ever seen God, he will actually be living in us, and....

4:12a**No one has ever seen God;**

- No human being has ever seen God as he really is,

No one has ever seen God: (Meaning) John means that no one has seen God as he really is, in spirit. People have only ever seen God at times when he has appeared in human form, such as when Moses saw him (Exodus 33:22–23) and when people saw Jesus.

4:12b**but if we love one another, God remains in us,**

- but even so, if/when we^(incl) love one another, God is united with us,

if we love: (Multiple Senses) This means “whenever we love...”

God remains in us: (Collocation) See the notes on 2:5c “in Him,” and 3:24a “and God in him.”

4:12c**and His love is perfected in us.**

- and his love is doing the work which he intends it to do in us.
- and he is loving people through us just as he wishes.

His love is perfected: (Meaning) John means that when God lives in us and we love others, then God’s love is reaching people just as he wants it to. In other words, God’s love is having the effect he intends it to have.

1 John 4:13**Section 4:7–5:12: We should love one another because of what God has done for us**

Read 4:7–5:12 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John gives two reasons why we should love one another:

4:7–12	God has shown us what true love is by sending his Son to die for us.
4:13–21	God has loved us so much that we have a duty to love others.

At the end of the section, in **5:1–12**, he shows how it is believing in Jesus that enables us to both love and obey God.

Paragraph 4:13–16

Read 4:13–16 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: These verses concentrate on one theme from 4:12, namely the fact that God lives in us and we live in him. John states three facts that prove that this is true:

4:13	We have the Holy Spirit.
4:14–15	We believe in Jesus as the Son of God.
4:16	Our lives are full of love.

4:13**By this we know that we remain in Him, and He in us: He has given us of His Spirit.**

- **¶** God has given us^(incl) his Holy Spirit, therefore we know that we are united with God and that God is united with us.

this: (Pronoun Reference) The word this points forward, referring to God’s gift of the Holy Spirit. The sentence may be restructured, but the emphasis of the sentence must be kept on God giving the Holy Spirit to us.

in Him: (Pronoun Reference) This refers to God, and since this verse starts a new paragraph it may be necessary to make the name explicit here. See GNT.

given us of His Spirit: (Meaning) This just means that God has put his Holy Spirit in us. Be careful in your translation that it does not sound as if God has simply handed over the Holy Spirit into our possession.

1 John 4:14

Section 4:7–5:12: We should love one another because of what God has done for us

Read 4:7–5:12 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John gives two reasons why we should love one another:

4:7–12	God has shown us what true love is by sending his Son to die for us.
4:13–21	God has loved us so much that we have a duty to love others.

At the end of the section, in **5:1–12**, he shows how it is believing in Jesus that enables us to both love and obey God.

Paragraph 4:13–16

Read 4:13–16 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: These verses concentrate on one theme from 4:12, namely the fact that God lives in us and we live in him. John states three facts that prove that this is true:

4:13	We have the Holy Spirit.
4:14–15	We believe in Jesus as the Son of God.
4:16	Our lives are full of love.

4:14

And we have seen and testify that the Father has sent His Son to be the Savior of the world.

- Also we^(excl) apostles have seen that God the Father sent his Son into this world in order to save everyone from the punishment of their sins, and we confirm to people that this is true.

we have seen: (Alternative Interpretations) There are two interpretations of the word we:

1. It is probably exclusive, meaning “we apostles” (as distinct from those John is writing this letter to). John is saying here the same thing that he said in 1:1.
2. Some think it is inclusive, in which case the sentence means “we apostles and you believers have come to know that it is true...that the Father sent...”

seen: (Meaning) John means that he and the other apostles saw Jesus throughout his ministry on earth and they know from experience that he was God’s Son who came to save the world.

testify: (Meaning) As in 1:2, this means to tell or confirm the truth about what one has seen.

to be the Savior: (Event Idea) The noun Savior translates a Greek word which expresses the idea of a person who saves people from some disaster. Here it refers to Christ as the one who saves people from the punishment which they deserve for their sins.

the world: (Multiple Senses) Here the word world refers to all human beings.

1 John 4:16

Section 4:7–5:12: We should love one another because of what God has done for us

Read 4:7–5:12 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John gives two reasons why we should love one another:

4:7–12	God has shown us what true love is by sending his Son to die for us.
4:13–21	God has loved us so much that we have a duty to love others.

At the end of the section, in **5:1–12**, he shows how it is believing in Jesus that enables us to both love and obey God.

Paragraph 4:13–16

Read 4:13–16 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: These verses concentrate on one theme from 4:12, namely the fact that God lives in us and we live in him. John states three facts that prove that this is true:

4:13	We have the Holy Spirit.
4:14–15	We believe in Jesus as the Son of God.
4:16	Our lives are full of love.

4:16d

abides in God, and God in him.

- he is united with God, and God is united with him.

4:16 (Alternative Interpretations)

There are different ways of understanding how this verse fits with the verses before and after it:

1. The whole verse is probably the third part of the section 4:13–16. (See the note on 4:13–16, Theme.) It should therefore be linked to the previous verse by a conjunction like “And/Also,” or by no conjunction at all. There is then a paragraph break after this verse.

2. Some think that the first sentence of this verse is a summary of 4:13–15, and that a new paragraph starts with the sentence “God is love.” In that case the verse should start with a phrase like “(And) so.” (NIV, GNT, NEB)

4:16a

And we have come to know and believe the love that God has for us.

- Also we^(incl) know well that God loves us, and we trust him to love us all the time.

we: (Pronoun System) If your language distinguishes between exclusive and inclusive “we,” you should mark the pronoun in this and the following verses as inclusive. It means “we apostles and you believers,” and contrasts with the exclusive “we” of 4:14.

the love that God has for us: (Meaning) This may be translated “God’s love for us” or “God loves us.” (See JB and Display.) It refers to all God’s love, both his past love in sending Christ as our Savior, and his present love expressed by the Holy Spirit in us.

4:16b

God is love;

- And because in everything he does God is always loving people,

God is love: (Meaning) See the note on 4:8b. The meaning is the same here.

4:16c

whoever abides in love

- we know that if a person keeps on loving God and other people

whoever abides...: (Logical Relationship) This is a result of the previous statement. It can be linked by a conjunction like “So,” or the two statements can be restructured as one sentence. See the Display.

abides in love: (Collocation) In your language it may sound unnatural to say that a person abides in an abstract quality like love. If so, this should be treated as a metaphor, and the basic meaning could be translated, as in the Display.

love: (Lexical Problem) In your language you may need to use a verb here and to make clear the object of the person’s love. Since John is talking about love in general, it would be best to translate, “loves other people and God.”

1 John 4:17

Section 4:7–5:12: We should love one another because of what God has done for us

Read 4:7–5:12 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John gives two reasons why we should love one another:

4:7–12	God has shown us what true love is by sending his Son to die for us.
4:13–21	God has loved us so much that we have a duty to love others.

At the end of the section, in **5:1–12**, he shows how it is believing in Jesus that enables us to both love and obey God.

Paragraph 4:17–18

Read 4:17–18 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: These verses concentrate on another theme from 4:12, namely God’s love being complete in us.

4:17a

In this way, love has been perfected among us,

- ¶ We^(incl) will know that God’s love has done all the work he intends it to do in us
- ¶ God will clearly have loved people through us just as he wishes

In this way: (Alternative Interpretations) There are different interpretations as to what the Greek pronoun translated this refers to here:

1. Probably it points forward to the second clause of the verse, “we have confidence...” (GNT, JB, NEB, JBP) Some of these translations therefore restructure the sentence.
2. Some think the pronoun refers back to the idea of loving and living in God in 4:16. (BSB, NIV later editions)

love has been perfected among us: (Meaning) This is the same phrase as in 4:12c, except that a different preposition “among” is used here instead of “in.” See the note on 4:12c.

4:17b

so that we may have confidence

- when we are not afraid of God

so that: (Alternative Interpretations) There are different interpretations of how the first and second clauses of this verse fit together:

1. Probably the first clause, “(God’s) love becomes complete in us” is explained by the second clause, “by our having confidence on the day of judgment.” (JB, NEB, JBP) John means that when we are allowing God to love us and to love others through us as he wants to, then we will not be afraid of God, even on the day of judgment.
2. Some think that the second clause gives the purpose of the first clause. (NIV, GNT)
3. Some think that the second clause gives the result of the first clause.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

4:17c

on the day of judgment;

- on the day when God will judge all people.

the day of judgment: (Biblical Term) This refers to the day when God will judge everyone, including believers.

4:17d

for in this world we are just like Him.

- We^(incl) will not be afraid of God because we have lived united with him in this world just as Jesus did.

for: (Logical Relationship) This gives the reason why we will have confidence on the day of judgment. In translation it may be necessary to make clear which clauses it links. See GNT and the Display.

in this world: (Multiple Senses) Here John uses this phrase to refer to our life on earth.

we are just like Him: (Alternative Interpretations) There are two interpretations of what this refers to, although it may not be necessary to make it explicit in translation:

1. It probably refers to God living in us and us living in God, just as God and Christ were always in one another.
2. It may refer to us being in a relationship of perfect love with God, as Christ was.

Him: (Pronoun Reference) This refers to Christ.

1 John 4:18

Section 4:7–5:12: We should love one another because of what God has done for us

Read 4:7–5:12 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John gives two reasons why we should love one another:

4:7–12	God has shown us what true love is by sending his Son to die for us.
--------	--

4:13–21	God has loved us so much that we have a duty to love others.
---------	--

At the end of the section, in **5:1–12**, he shows how it is believing in Jesus that enables us to both love and obey God.

Paragraph 4:17–18

Read 4:17–18 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: These verses concentrate on another theme from 4:12, namely God’s love being complete in us.

4:18a

There is no fear in love,

- Any person who
- God loves will not be afraid
- of God.

There is no fear: (Event Idea) Here John uses a noun, fear, to express the idea of being afraid. The rest of the verse makes it clear that he is talking about being afraid of God, so if the verb “fear” requires an object in your language, “God” can be made explicit here.

in love: (Event Idea) Again a noun, love, is used to express an event idea, “loving.” Here it probably means “when God loves someone/us.”

4:18b

but perfect love

- So if/when God’s love is doing the work he intends it to do in us^(incl)
- So when God is loving people through us^(incl) just as he wishes

4:18c

drives out fear,

- we cannot be afraid of God at all.

4:18b–c

perfect love drives out fear: (Metaphor) This clause repeats the meaning of the previous one, using the metaphor of someone expelling an enemy from a place. For a restatement of this clause without the metaphor see the Display.

4:18d

because fear involves punishment.

- This is because people are afraid of God since they know he will punish them.

fear involves punishment: (Alternative Interpretations) There are two views of what this means:

1. It probably means “the reason why people are afraid of God is that they know he will punish them on the day of judgement.” (JB, LB)
2. Some think it means “when someone is afraid of God he is causing himself to suffer just as if God was punishing him.” (NEB, JBP)

4:18e**The one who fears**

- So if someone is afraid of God,

who fears: (Lexical Problem) Again the implied object of this verb is God.

4:18f**has not been perfected in love.**

- it shows that God’s love is not doing the work God intends it to do in him.
- he is clearly not letting God love people through him as God wants to.

been perfected in love: (Meaning) This means the same as “love has been perfected” in 4:17a and “love is perfected” in 4:12c. See the note on 4:12c.

1 John 4:19**Section 4:7–5:12: We should love one another because of what God has done for us**

Read 4:7–5:12 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John gives two reasons why we should love one another:

4:7–12	God has shown us what true love is by sending his Son to die for us.
4:13–21	God has loved us so much that we have a duty to love others.

At the end of the section, in **5:1–12**, he shows how it is believing in Jesus that enables us to both love and obey God.

Paragraph 4:19–21

Read 4:19–21 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: This is the summary of John’s appeal that we should love other Christians because God has loved us so much.

4:19a**We love**

- ¶ What gives us^(incl) power to love God and other people

We love: (Lexical Problem) No object for this verb is expressed in the Greek. However John is talking about

our love for God and for other people, so this may be made explicit if the verb “love” has to have an expressed object in your language. See Display.

The KJV and LB use the pronoun “him” in this verse part, but that is based on an inferior Greek text.

4:19b**because He first loved us.**

- is that God loved us long ago before we loved him.

because: (Alternative Interpretations) There are different views on what ideas this implies and connects:

1. It probably means that God’s love for us gives us the power to love.
2. Some think it means that we have a duty to love because God loves us.
3. Others think it means we are able to love because God’s love gives us the example to follow.

It is recommended that you follow interpretation (1).

He: (Pronoun Reference) This refers to God. See GNT.

first: (Multiple Senses) This is used here in the sense of “before/previously.” John means that God loved us before we loved him or others.

1 John 4:20**Section 4:7–5:12: We should love one another because of what God has done for us**

Read 4:7–5:12 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John gives two reasons why we should love one another:

4:7–12	God has shown us what true love is by sending his Son to die for us.
4:13–21	God has loved us so much that we have a duty to love others.

At the end of the section, in **5:1–12**, he shows how it is believing in Jesus that enables us to both love and obey God.

Paragraph 4:19–21

Read 4:19–21 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: This is the summary of John’s appeal that we should love other Christians because God has loved us so much.

4:20a**If anyone says, “I love God,”**

- Anyone who says that he loves God,

says, “I love God”: (Speech Quotation) This is not the quotation of what someone actually said. It is an example of what someone might say. Therefore in translation it is important to consider whether it should be in direct speech or in indirect speech. See GNT and the Display.

4:20b
but hates his brother,

- while he is treating a fellow Christian unkindly,

but hates his brother: (Multiple Senses) As in 2:9b, this means treating fellow Christians in a bad way, without love. See the notes on 2:9b.

4:20c
he is a liar.

- that person is telling lies.

he is a liar: (Meaning) In other words, he does not really love God. He is deceiving people when he says he loves God.

4:20d
For anyone who does not love his brother, whom he has seen, cannot love God, whom he has not seen.

- We^(incl) know that he is telling lies because it is impossible for a person to be loving God, whom he has never seen, if he is not loving his fellow Christian whom he always sees.

For: (Logical Relationship) This conjunction shows that the rest of the verse explains how we know that such a person is a liar.

his brother, whom he has seen: (Meaning) This is not referring to a specific brother. John is giving a general example, saying that our fellow Christians are people we see all the time, whereas God cannot be seen at all.

cannot love God: (Meaning) John is saying that if we do not love our brothers, it is impossible for us to truly claim to be loving God. Since this is a strong negative statement, it may be expressed in some languages as a rhetorical question. See JBP, LB.

1 John 4:21

Section 4:7–5:12: We should love one another because of what God has done for us

Read 4:7–5:12 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John gives two reasons why we should love one another:

4:7–12	God has shown us what true love is by sending his Son to die for us.
--------	--

4:13–21	God has loved us so much that we have a duty to love others.
---------	--

At the end of the section, in **5:1–12**, he shows how it is believing in Jesus that enables us to both love and obey God.

Paragraph 4:19–21

Read 4:19–21 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: This is the summary of John’s appeal that we should love other Christians because God has loved us so much.

4:21a
And we have this commandment from Him:

- Also we^(incl) must love our fellow Christians because this is what God has told us we should do.

And: (Logical Relationship) This verse says that another reason why we must love other Christians is that God has commanded it.

we have this commandment from Him: (Alternative Interpretations) There are two interpretations of who the pronoun Him refers to here:

1. It probably refers to God. (LB)
2. Some think it refers to Christ. (GNT, NEB)

4:21b
Whoever loves God must love his brother as well.

- God said that anyone who loves him should also love other Christians.

1 John 5:1

Section 4:7–5:12: We should love one another because of what God has done for us

Read 4:7–5:12 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John gives two reasons why we should love one another:

4:7–12	God has shown us what true love is by sending his Son to die for us.
4:13–21	God has loved us so much that we have a duty to love others.

At the end of the section, in **5:1–12**, he shows how it is believing in Jesus that enables us to both love and obey God.

Paragraph 5:1–5

Read 5:1–5 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: These verses show that believing in Jesus is what makes us all fellow Christians. They also show that if we believe in Jesus we have power to love and to obey God’s commands.

5:1 (Logical Relationship)

Although this verse starts a new paragraph, it is still connected in thought with the last paragraph of Chapter 4. There John talked about loving our brothers. Here he makes clear who our brothers are. They are all those who truly believe in Jesus.

5:1a

Everyone who believes that Jesus is the Christ

- ¶ Whoever believes that Jesus is the Christ/Messiah who God sent to this world

the Christ: (Biblical Term) As in 2:22a, Christ here is not just a name. It is the title or description of the one who God would send from heaven to save and rule his people. See Christ in Key Biblical Terms.

5:1b

has been born of God,

- is a child of God.

been born of God: (Meaning) As in 3:9a, this means being a child of God. See GNT, NEB, RSV, JBP, LB.

5:1c

and everyone who loves the Father

- And we^(incl) know that if we love someone who is a father,

5:1d

also loves those born of Him.

- we will also love that person’s child/children.

5:1c–d

everyone who loves the Father also loves those born of Him: (Alternative Interpretations) The point that John is making here is that all who truly love God also love his children. However some think John is making this point indirectly and some think he is making it directly:

1. Probably John is making his point here indirectly by stating a generally well known truth, that those who love someone love that person’s children also. (NIV, GNT, NEB, RSV)
2. It may be that John is directly saying that those who love our father God also love God’s children. (BSB, JB, JBP, LB)

1 John 5:2

Section 4:7–5:12: We should love one another because of what God has done for us

Read 4:7–5:12 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John gives two reasons why we should love one another:

4:7–12	God has shown us what true love is by sending his Son to die for us.
4:13–21	God has loved us so much that we have a duty to love others.

At the end of the section, in **5:1–12**, he shows how it is believing in Jesus that enables us to both love and obey God.

Paragraph 5:1–5

Read 5:1–5 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: These verses show that believing in Jesus is what makes us all fellow Christians. They also show that if we believe in Jesus we have power to love and to obey God’s commands.

5:2a

By this we know that we love the children of God:

- So we^(incl) know certainly that we are truly loving God’s children

By this: (Alternative Interpretations) There are two views as to what the word this refers to:

1. It is probably giving emphasis to the second half of the verse.
2. Some think it refers back to the idea in 5:1 that whenever we love someone we also love their children. (NEB)

5:2b

when we love God and keep His commandments.

- if/when we are loving God and are doing what he has told us to do.

1 John 5:3

Section 4:7–5:12: We should love one another because of what God has done for us

Read 4:7–5:12 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John gives two reasons why we should love one another:

4:7–12	God has shown us what true love is by sending his Son to die for us.
--------	--

4:13-21	God has loved us so much that we have a duty to love others.
---------	--

At the end of the section, in **5:1-12**, he shows how it is believing in Jesus that enables us to both love and obey God.

Paragraph 5:1-5

Read 5:1-5 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: These verses show that believing in Jesus is what makes us all fellow Christians. They also show that if we believe in Jesus we have power to love and to obey God's commands.

5:3b

that we keep His commandments.

- we will certainly do what he has told us to do.

5:3a-b

For this is the love of God, that we keep His commandments: (Meaning) John means that true love for God always involves obeying his commands. It is impossible to love God while at the same time disobeying him.

5:3a

For this is the love of God,

- I say this because if we^(incl) truly love God,

For: (Logical Relationship) In the Greek the connecting word here shows that this statement (5:3a-b) explains why in the last verse John linked obeying God with loving God.

5:3c

And His commandments are not burdensome,

- It is not difficult for us to do what he has told us to do,

His commandments are not burdensome: (Metaphor) John's meaning is that God's commands are not difficult for us to obey. In the next verse he gives the reason why it is not hard for us to obey God.

1 John 5:4

Section 4:7-5:12: We should love one another because of what God has done for us

Read 4:7-5:12 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John gives two reasons why we should love one another:

4:7-12	God has shown us what true love is by sending his Son to die for us.
--------	--

4:13-21	God has loved us so much that we have a duty to love others.
---------	--

At the end of the section, in **5:1-12**, he shows how it is believing in Jesus that enables us to both love and obey God.

Paragraph 5:1-5

Read 5:1-5 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: These verses show that believing in Jesus is what makes us all fellow Christians. They also show that if we believe in Jesus we have power to love and to obey God's commands.

5:4a

because everyone born of God overcomes the world.

- because every child of God is able to reject the evil ways of human beings.

born of God: (Meaning) See the note on 5:1b.

overcomes the world: (Metaphor) With this metaphor John is saying that Christians can successfully resist the temptation to follow the ways of this world. And normally this is what they do. Therefore nothing can force us to disobey God. He is not saying that we have actually defeated the people of this world in some fight.

the world: (Multiple Senses) In this verse the world means the evil ways of human beings and everything in the world that is opposed to God.

5:4b

And this is the victory that has overcome the world: our faith.

- The reason why we^(incl) are able to reject the evil ways of human beings is because we believe in Jesus.

victory that has overcome: (Lexical Problem) This is a figure of speech meaning "the thing which has enabled us to overcome."

our faith: (Emphasis) John is here emphasizing that it is through our continuing to trust God that we are able to overcome the world.

faith: (Biblical Term) See believe in Key Biblical Terms. The next verse makes clear that here faith refers to believing in Jesus as God's Son.

1 John 5:5

Section 4:7–5:12: We should love one another because of what God has done for us

Read 4:7–5:12 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John gives two reasons why we should love one another:

4:7–12	God has shown us what true love is by sending his Son to die for us.
4:13–21	God has loved us so much that we have a duty to love others.

At the end of the section, in **5:1–12**, he shows how it is believing in Jesus that enables us to both love and obey God.

Paragraph 5:1–5

Read 5:1–5 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: These verses show that believing in Jesus is what makes us all fellow Christians. They also show that if we believe in Jesus we have power to love and to obey God's commands.

5:5a

Who then overcomes the world?

- No one else is able to reject the evil ways of human beings

Who then overcomes the world?: (Rhetorical Question) This rhetorical question is used to emphasize the statement in the second half of the verse that no one can overcome the world except those who believe that Jesus is the Son of God.

5:5b

Only he who believes that Jesus is the Son of God.

- except those who believe that Jesus is God's Son.

he who believes: (Pronoun Reference) This means "anyone who believes" or "all who believe."

1 John 5:6

Section 4:7–5:12: We should love one another because of what God has done for us

Read 4:7–5:12 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John gives two reasons why we should love one another:

4:7–12	God has shown us what true love is by sending his Son to die for us.
4:13–21	God has loved us so much that we have a duty to love others.

At the end of the section, in **5:1–12**, he shows how it is believing in Jesus that enables us to both love and obey God.

Paragraph 5:6–9

Read 5:6–9 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: In 5:5 John has talked about believing that Jesus is the Son of God. In 5:6–9 he explains why we should believe in Jesus as the son of God.

5:6a

This is the One who came by water and blood, Jesus Christ—

- ¶ It is he, Jesus Christ, who came to this world from heaven, and later John baptized him with water, and later when he died his blood poured out.

This: (Pronoun Reference) The word This refers to "Jesus Christ." In translation it may be clearer to put the name at the beginning of the sentence (see GNT), or to indicate in some other way that the name "Jesus Christ" is in focus here.

the One who came: (Meaning) John is not contrasting Jesus with someone else. He is emphasizing two important points about Jesus' ministry on earth which those who believe in him (see 5:5) must accept.

by water and blood: (Alternative Interpretations) There are different views about what events in Jesus' ministry John is referring to by these figures of speech:

1. He is probably emphasizing that Jesus Christ, who came from heaven, was baptized in water to identify himself with us human beings and shed his blood when he died to save us. In your translation, you will probably need to make clear that water is a figure of speech for Jesus' baptism, and blood is a figure of speech for his death. See GNT.
2. Some think John is referring to the fact that Jesus gave us the sacraments of baptism (water) and communion (blood) to remind us of what he has done for us.
3. Some think this is a reference to the water and blood which came out of Jesus' body on the cross (John 19:34), proving that he had really died.

5:6b

not by water alone,

- It is not true that the only thing that happened to him was that John baptized him with water.

5:6c

but by water and blood.

- No, he also died and his blood poured out.

5:6b–c

not by water alone, but by water and blood: (Meaning) Here John is denying the teaching of various false teachers who claimed that Jesus was just a man who became Son of God when he was baptized and ceased to be Son of God before he was crucified. That is why John emphasizes here that Jesus Christ, the Son of God, not only was baptized but also died.

5:6d

And it is the Spirit who testifies to this,

- The Holy Spirit shows us^(incl) that these things are true,

testifies to this: (Lexical Problem) John does not specify here what the Holy Spirit testifies about. However the following verses make it clear that he is referring to the truth about Jesus Christ, the Son of God. GNT makes this reference more explicit. The Holy Spirit testifies to this fact in the hearts or minds of believers.

5:6e

because the Spirit is the truth.

- because he is the one who always shows people what is true.

is the truth: (Meaning) For the basic meaning of “truth” see the note on 3:19b “we belong to the truth.” Here John means that the Holy Spirit is the one who shows us the whole of God’s nature and his deeds.

1 John 5:7

Section 4:7–5:12: We should love one another because of what God has done for us

Read 4:7–5:12 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John gives two reasons why we should love one another:

4:7–12	God has shown us what true love is by sending his Son to die for us.
4:13–21	God has loved us so much that we have a duty to love others.

At the end of the section, in **5:1–12**, he shows how it is believing in Jesus that enables us to both love and obey God.

Paragraph 5:6–9

Read 5:6–9 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: In 5:5 John has talked about believing that Jesus is the Son of God. In 5:6–9 he explains why we should believe in Jesus as the son of God.

5:7

For there are three that testify:

- So there are in fact three signs/ways by which we know the truth about Jesus.

three that testify: (Lexical Problem) John means that there are three things which show us the truth about Jesus. However, in your language it may not be possible to refer to the Holy Spirit and Jesus’ baptism and his death with one general term like “things.” See the Display for 5:7–8 for a suggested solution to this problem. 5:7 The rest of this verse and the beginning of 5:8 in KJV is not found in any reliable Greek manuscript and is therefore omitted from all other English translations.

1 John 5:8

Section 4:7–5:12: We should love one another because of what God has done for us

Read 4:7–5:12 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John gives two reasons why we should love one another:

4:7–12	God has shown us what true love is by sending his Son to die for us.
4:13–21	God has loved us so much that we have a duty to love others.

At the end of the section, in **5:1–12**, he shows how it is believing in Jesus that enables us to both love and obey God.

Paragraph 5:6–9

Read 5:6–9 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: In 5:5 John has talked about believing that Jesus is the Son of God. In 5:6–9 he explains why we should believe in Jesus as the son of God.

**5:8a
the Spirit,**

- We^(incl) know the truth about Jesus because the Holy Spirit speaks to us,

**5:8b
the water,**

- and because John baptized Jesus with water,

**5:8c
and the blood—**

- and because Jesus died and his blood poured out.

5:8a–c

the Spirit, the water, and the blood: (Meaning) The meanings of these terms are the same as in 5:6 and they should be translated in the same way here.

5:8d

and these three are in agreement.

- These three signs/ways all show us^(incl) the same thing.

are in agreement: (Meaning) John means that these three things all prove the same thing about Jesus, namely that he was the Son of God.

1 John 5:9

Section 4:7–5:12: We should love one another because of what God has done for us

Read 4:7–5:12 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John gives two reasons why we should love one another:

4:7–12	God has shown us what true love is by sending his Son to die for us.
4:13–21	God has loved us so much that we have a duty to love others.

At the end of the section, in **5:1–12**, he shows how it is believing in Jesus that enables us to both love and obey God.

Paragraph 5:6–9

Read 5:6–9 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: In 5:5 John has talked about believing that Jesus is the Son of God. In 5:6–9 he explains why we should believe in Jesus as the son of God.

5:9a

Even if we accept human testimony,

- When people tell about things which they know, we^(incl) believe them.

Even if we accept human testimony: (Meaning) John is giving this as a general example to prove his point. He is saying that people normally accept what others tell them about what they have seen, therefore people should accept what God says about his Son. See the Display.

5:9b

the testimony of God is greater.

- So we^(incl) should accept these things which God shows us, because whatever God tells us is much more important/trustworthy than what people tell us.

greater: (Lexical Problem) Although it is not specified in what respect God's testimony is greater than man's testimony, it is clear from the rest of the verse that John means that it is more worthy of acceptance.

5:9c

For this is the testimony

- It is much more important because he is God not just a human being,

For: (Logical Relationship) John gives two reasons why God's testimony is greater: firstly, it is God, not a man, who is giving it, and secondly, it is about God's own Son, not about something else.

5:9d

that God has given about His Son.

- and because it is his own Son that he is telling us about.

1 John 5:10

Section 4:7–5:12: We should love one another because of what God has done for us

Read 4:7–5:12 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John gives two reasons why we should love one another:

4:7–12	God has shown us what true love is by sending his Son to die for us.
4:13–21	God has loved us so much that we have a duty to love others.

At the end of the section, in **5:1–12**, he shows how it is believing in Jesus that enables us to both love and obey God.

Paragraph 5:10–12

Read 5:10–12 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: Here John shows that believing in Jesus can cause us to be confident that we have eternal life.

5:10a

Whoever believes in the Son of God

- ¶ So if anyone believes in Jesus as the Son of God,

5:10b

has this testimony within him;

- he knows for certain that these things which God has shown him are true.

this testimony: (Pronoun Reference) This refers to the testimony mentioned in the previous verses (5:6–9) by

which the Holy Spirit assures us that Jesus Christ is the Son of God.

within him: (Meaning) This means that such a person has no doubts that these things are true because he is fully assured of them in himself.

5:10c

whoever does not believe God

- But if anyone does not believe what God has said,

whoever does not believe God: (Logical Relationship) Even though this sentence refers to God instead of Jesus Christ, it is meant as a direct contrast to the last sentence (5:10a–b). In translation a conjunction such as “but” may be needed to introduce it. See GNT, NEB.

does not believe God: (Meaning) This refers to not believing what God says about his Son. It does not mean, “does not believe in God.”

5:10d

has made Him out to be a liar,

- he is saying that God is a liar,
- he is showing that he thinks God does not tell the truth,

has made Him out: (Meaning) John means that to refuse to believe God is the same as saying that God is a liar.

5:10e

because he has not believed in the testimony that God has given about His Son.

- because he has rejected what God has said about God’s own Son.

because: (Logical Relationship) This gives the reason why John says that refusing to believe God is the same as saying he is a liar.

1 John 5:11

Section 4:7–5:12: We should love one another because of what God has done for us

Read 4:7–5:12 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John gives two reasons why we should love one another:

4:7–12	God has shown us what true love is by sending his Son to die for us.
4:13–21	God has loved us so much that we have a duty to love others.

At the end of the section, in **5:1–12**, he shows how it is believing in Jesus that enables us to both love and obey God.

Paragraph 5:10–12

Read 5:10–12 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: Here John shows that believing in Jesus can cause us to be confident that we have eternal life.

5:11a–b

God has given us eternal life, and this life is in His Son: (Alternative Interpretations) There are two views about how this sentence relates to the term “testimony”:

1. This sentence is probably stating how God puts his testimony in our hearts. See the Display.
2. Some think that it is stating what the testimony is.

5:11a

And this is that testimony: God has given us eternal life,

- What causes us^(incl) to be sure about what God has said is the fact that he has given us eternal heavenly life.
- We^(incl) know that what God has said to us is true because he has caused us to begin to live with him for ever.

this is: (Pronoun Reference) This refers to the rest of the verse.

5:11b

and this life is in His Son.

- It is through God’s Son that we^(incl) have received this life.
- God causes us^(incl) to live with him for ever by giving his Son to be united with us.

this life is in His Son: (Collocation) This does not just mean that Christ has eternal life. John is saying that we only get eternal life through Christ. God gives it to us by means of uniting us with his Son.

1 John 5:12

Section 4:7–5:12: We should love one another because of what God has done for us

Read 4:7–5:12 carefully.

Section Theme: In this section John gives two reasons why we should love one another:

4:7–12	God has shown us what true love is by sending his Son to die for us.
--------	--

4:13-21	God has loved us so much that we have a duty to love others.
---------	--

At the end of the section, in **5:1-12**, he shows how it is believing in Jesus that enables us to both love and obey God.

Paragraph 5:10-12

Read 5:10-12 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: Here John shows that believing in Jesus can cause us to be confident that we have eternal life.

5:12a

Whoever has the Son has life;

- So anyone who is united with God's Son has this eternal heavenly life,
- So if anyone has accepted the Son of God, he is living with God for ever.

Whoever: (Meaning) This just means "anyone who..." or "all those who..."

has the Son: (Meaning) This is another way by which John refers to our close personal relationship and union with Christ. It means the same as the phrase "in Christ." See the note on 2:5c "in Him."

life: (Pronoun Reference) The Greek has "the life" here, making it clear that "eternal life" (5:11) is meant. In translation it may be clearer to say "this life." See GNT.

5:12b

whoever does not have the Son of God does not have life.

- But anyone who is not united with God's Son does not have this eternal heavenly life.
- But if anyone has not accepted the Son of God, he is not living with God at all.

whoever does not: (Emphasis) In this sentence John is emphasizing what he has just said in 5:12a by restating it in the negative. A word like "but" may be needed to link the two sentences.

1 John 5:13

Section 5:13-21: We can be sure that we have eternal life

Read 5:13-21 carefully.

Section Theme: John ends his letter by reassuring his readers that they do have eternal life and that they do truly know God.

Paragraph 5:13-17

Read 5:13-17 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: John reminds his readers that because they have eternal life they can have confidence when they ask God for anything. Praying for other Christians who are sinning is an example of this.

5:13b

so that you may know that you have eternal life.

- so that you may be sure that you have eternal heavenly life.
- so that you may not doubt that you are living with God for ever.

5:13 (Focus)

This verse is a summary of John's purpose in writing this letter. In it he focuses on two things: firstly that his readers must believe in Jesus, and secondly that they should not doubt that they have eternal life.

5:13a

I have written these things to you who believe in the name of the Son of God,

- ¶ I have written everything in this letter to you who believe in Jesus' authority as the Son of God

these things: (Pronoun Reference) John is referring back to all the things he has written in this letter.

believe in the name: (Biblical Term) As in 3:23b, this means believing or trusting Jesus' authority and character as God's Son.

1 John 5:14

Section 5:13-21: We can be sure that we have eternal life

Read 5:13-21 carefully.

Section Theme: John ends his letter by reassuring his readers that they do have eternal life and that they do truly know God.

Paragraph 5:13-17

Read 5:13-17 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: John reminds his readers that because they have eternal life they can have confidence when they ask God for anything. Praying for other Christians who are sinning is an example of this.

5:14b

If we ask anything

- because we know that whenever we ask him for something

5:14 (Logical Relationship)

In this and the following verses John states one result of our having eternal life, namely that we can be sure our prayers are answered. You may need to make this connection with the previous verse clear in your translation. See the Display.

5:14a

And this is the confidence that we have before Him:

- And so we^(incl) are not afraid when we pray to God,

the confidence that we have before Him: (Meaning)

This represents the same Greek phrase “we have confidence before God” in 3:21b. It means that we are not afraid or ashamed to ask God for things.

5:14c

according to His will, He hears us.

- he always agrees to our request if it is what he wants us to ask for.
- he never refuses us if our thoughts are the same as his.

according to His will: (Meaning) This means that what we want is the same as what God wants, because we are united with him through Jesus and so our deeds and thoughts are the same as his.

hears us: (Connotation) This word implies that God both hears our requests and agrees to give us what we ask for.

1 John 5:15

Section 5:13–21: We can be sure that we have eternal life

Read 5:13–21 carefully.

Section Theme: John ends his letter by reassuring his readers that they do have eternal life and that they do truly know God.

Paragraph 5:13–17

Read 5:13–17 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: John reminds his readers that because they have eternal life they can have confidence when they ask God for anything. Praying for other Christians who are sinning is an example of this.

5:15b

whatever we ask,

- whenever we ask him for something that he wants us to ask for,

5:15a–b

He hears us in whatever we ask: (Logical Relationship) This repeats what John has said in the previous

verse. When he says whatever we ask he is assuming that this will be “according to His will” as he mentioned in verse 14.

5:15a

And if we know that He hears us in

- Therefore, since we^(incl) know that he never refuses us

if we know: (Multiple Senses) The word if here is used with the meaning of “since/because.” See GNT.

5:15c

we know that we already possess what we have asked of Him.

- we are sure that he gives us everything which we ask him for.

we already possess: (Tense) The tense used in the Greek here shows that God grants Christians’ requests at the very moment we make them. When we ask for something we already have it.

1 John 5:16

Section 5:13–21: We can be sure that we have eternal life

Read 5:13–21 carefully.

Section Theme: John ends his letter by reassuring his readers that they do have eternal life and that they do truly know God.

Paragraph 5:13–17

Read 5:13–17 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: John reminds his readers that because they have eternal life they can have confidence when they ask God for anything. Praying for other Christians who are sinning is an example of this.

5:16a–b

committing a sin not leading to death: (Alternative Interpretations) In this verse and the next John talks about “sin that leads to death.” There are different interpretations of what this refers to:

1. It probably refers to the sins of deliberately rejecting Christ and hating his people. These sins show that those who commit them do not have eternal life and are, in fact, spiritually dead. This is what John has made clear in 5:12 and in 3:14.
2. Some think it refers to the sin of blaspheming against the Holy Spirit. See Matthew 12:31–32.
3. Others think that it refers to Christians who abandon their faith. See Hebrews 6:4–6.

5:16a**If anyone sees his brother committing a sin**

- So, if/when anyone of you knows that a fellow Christian is sinning,

anyone: (Pronoun Reference) This does not mean anyone at all whoever he may be. John is giving an instruction to his readers, so it may be clearer in translation to say “anyone of you.” See GNT, JBP, LB.

sees: (Multiple Senses) This refers not just to seeing with the eyes, but also to knowing about something, being aware of it.

his brother: (Alternative Interpretations) There are two views as to the sense in which this word is used here:

1. It probably means any other Christian.
2. Some think it means any other person, Christian or not.

5:16b**not leading to death,**

- and if that sin is not the type of sin which will separate that person from God forever,

leading to death: (Meaning) In all the interpretations mentioned in the last note this phrase means spiritual death, not physical death. That is to say, doing this type of sin causes a person to be separated forever from God and from the life which God gives through Christ. John is not referring to sins of witchcraft which cause other people to die.

5:16c**he should ask God,**

- he should ask God to save that person.

ask God: (Multiple Senses) This verb is used here with the sense of asking God for something. In this case it means asking God to save the brother who is committing the sin.

5:16d**who will give life**

- Then God will certainly cause that person to live truly.

5:16e**to those who commit this kind of sin.**

- I am talking about people whose sin is not the type that will separate them from God for ever.

5:16d-e

who will give life to those: (Meaning) Since this refers to someone who is already a believer, it may be best to say, “who will restore to (spiritual) life those.”

5:16f**There is a sin that leads to death;**

- But it is different for those who are doing sins which separate them from God forever.
- Some sins do, in fact, separate people from God forever.

There is a sin: (Alternative Interpretations) There are different views about the meaning of the grammar of the Greek in this phrase:

1. It probably means “There is a type of sin...” or “There are some sins...” (GNT, NEB, RSV)
2. Some think it means “There is one particular sin...” (BSB, NIV, JB, KJV, LB)

5:16g**I am not saying he should ask regarding that sin.**

- I am not saying that you ought to ask God to save someone who is doing that type of sin.

I am not saying he should ask regarding that sin:

(Meaning) It is easy to misunderstand this sentence. John’s meaning here is that he will not instruct his readers that they ought to pray about people who commit sins which lead to death. He will not command them to pray for those people because they have deliberately rejected all God’s help. But he allows them to pray for such people if they want to (because we do not know if possibly God may save them). Your translation should not make it sound as if John is forbidding prayer for these people.

1 John 5:17**Section 5:13–21: We can be sure that we have eternal life**

Read 5:13–21 carefully.

Section Theme: John ends his letter by reassuring his readers that they do have eternal life and that they do truly know God.

Paragraph 5:13–17

Read 5:13–17 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: John reminds his readers that because they have eternal life they can have confidence when they ask God for anything. Praying for other Christians who are sinning is an example of this.

5:17 (Logical Relationship)

In the previous verse John has mentioned two types of sin, those which lead to death and those which do not. In this verse he is making his readers understand that the sins which do not lead to death are also very bad. All sin is serious in God’s sight.

5:17a**All unrighteousness is sin,**

- Any type of wrong that a person does is a sin against God.

All unrighteousness is sin: (Lexical Problem) The terms unrighteousness and sin are often used to mean the same thing, but here they are used with more specific meanings. In this verse unrighteousness means any act which is against God's will or is below the standard he sets. Here, sin means something which offends God and spoils or breaks a person's relationship with him.

5:17b**yet there is sin that does not lead to death.**

- But there are many sins which do not separate people from God for ever.

yet there is: (Logical Relationship) The BSB translates the Greek conjunction used here as yet. Since this statement contrasts with the first half of the verse the English conjunction "but" is another translation option here. See GNT, JB, NEB, RSV, JBP.

1 John 5:18**Section 5:13–21: We can be sure that we have eternal life**

Read 5:13–21 carefully.

Section Theme: John ends his letter by reassuring his readers that they do have eternal life and that they do truly know God.

Paragraph 5:18–21

Read 5:18–21 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: Finally John reminds the readers that God protects them from the temptation to sin and that they really do know God, so they should reject all false teaching.

5:18a**We know that anyone born of God does not keep on sinning;**

- ¶ We^(incl) know that anyone who has become a child of God does not sin continually,

anyone born of God does not keep on sinning: (Meaning) The Greek for this clause is almost exactly the same as 3:9, "Anyone born of God refuses to practice sin." It means that no child of God should be continually or habitually sinning.

5:18b**the One who was born of God protects him,**

- because God's Son, Jesus Christ, protects him,

(Logical Relationship) The rest of the verse gives the reason why Christians do not continually sin. This connection may be clearer if a conjunction such as "because" is used.

the One who was born of God: (Tense) The tense of the Greek verb here is different from the tense of "anyone born of God" in 5:18a. It indicates that in 5:18b John is referring to a specific person who was once born of God. Several translations make this reference clearer by translating it as "the Son of God." See GNT, JB, NEB, JBP, LB.

protects him: (Connotation) This implies that the Son of God keeps that person safe from Satan's attempts to lead him into sin. 5:18 (Text) The pronoun himself in KJV is based on a Greek text which is generally considered inferior.

5:18c**and the evil one cannot touch him.**

- so that Satan, who causes all evil, cannot harm him in any way.

and: (Logical Relationship) The clause in 5:18c can be considered as a result of the Son of God keeping the Christian safe. So it may be clearer in translation to link it with a conjunction such as "and so" or "so that."

the evil one: (Meaning) As in 2:13e, this is a common way of referring to Satan.

touch: (Connotation) This word implies the idea of touching someone with the intention of doing something bad to that person. It may therefore be clearer to translate it by "harm." See GNT and later editions of NIV.

1 John 5:19**Section 5:13–21: We can be sure that we have eternal life**

Read 5:13–21 carefully.

Section Theme: John ends his letter by reassuring his readers that they do have eternal life and that they do truly know God.

Paragraph 5:18–21

Read 5:18–21 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: Finally John reminds the readers that God protects them from the temptation to sin and that they really do know God, so they should reject all false teaching.

5:19a**We know that we are of God,**

- We^(incl) know that we are God's children

5:19b**and that the whole world is under the power of the evil one.**

- and that Satan rules/controls everyone who does not know God.

the whole world: (Multiple Senses) In this verse this phrase means all those people in the world who have not accepted God.

1 John 5:20**Section 5:13–21: We can be sure that we have eternal life**

Read 5:13–21 carefully.

Section Theme: John ends his letter by reassuring his readers that they do have eternal life and that they do truly know God.

Paragraph 5:18–21

Read 5:18–21 in both BSB and GNT. Compare the two versions.

Paragraph Theme: Finally John reminds the readers that God protects them from the temptation to sin and that they really do know God, so they should reject all false teaching.

5:20a**And we know that the Son of God has come**

- We^(incl) know that God's Son has come to this world

has come: (Meaning) This refers to the fact that Jesus came into the world.

5:20b**and has given us understanding, so that we may know Him who is true;**

- and has caused us to be able to know the only true/real God.

has given us understanding: (Collocation) In your language it may not be possible to “give” an abstract thing like understanding, or it may not be clear in what way this is done. Here the basic meaning is that Jesus has caused us to understand or know something.

understanding: (Lexical Problem) The thing that is understood is not mentioned here, but its result is given in the next clause, “so that we may know him....” Therefore John's meaning is that Jesus has given us the ability or power to know him who is true.

Him who is true: (Meaning) John is here referring to God, whom Jesus has caused us to know. He is saying that this is the real God, in contrast to the false gods of other religions and in contrast to false teachings about the God of Christianity.

5:20c**and we are in Him who is true—**

- We are united with this only true/real God

in Him: (Collocation) As in 2:5c, this means that we are in union with God, in a close personal relationship with him.

5:20d**in His Son Jesus Christ.**

- because we are united with his Son, Jesus Christ.

in: (Ellipsis) This clause explains how we are “in God.” The full meaning is “because we are in his Son, Jesus Christ.”

5:20e**He is the true God**

- There is no other true/real God.

He: (Alternative Interpretations) There are different views about who the pronoun He refers to:

1. It probably refers to God.
2. Some think it refers to Christ. (LB)

5:20f**and eternal life.**

- God is the only one who gives people eternal heavenly life.
- He is the only one who can make people live with him for ever.

and eternal life: (Meaning) John means that God is the only source of eternal life. We have eternal life by being united to God.